On the Context Sensitivity of LLM Moral Judgment

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Abstract

A human's moral decision depends heavily on the context. Yet research on LLM morality has largely studied fixed scenarios. We address this gap by introducing Contextual MoralChoice, a dataset of moral dilemmas with systematic contextual variations known from moral psychology to shift human judgment: consequentialist, emotional, and relational. Evaluating 22 LLMs, we find that nearly all models are context-sensitive, shifting their judgments towards rule-violating behavior. Comparing with a human survey, we find that models and humans are most triggered by different contextual variations, and that a model aligned with human judgments in the base case is not necessarily aligned in its contextual sensitivity. This raises the question of controlling contextual sensitivity, which we address with an activation steering approach that can reliably increase or decrease a model's contextual sensitivity. Code and data: https://github.com/adrian-sauter/contextual_moralchoice.

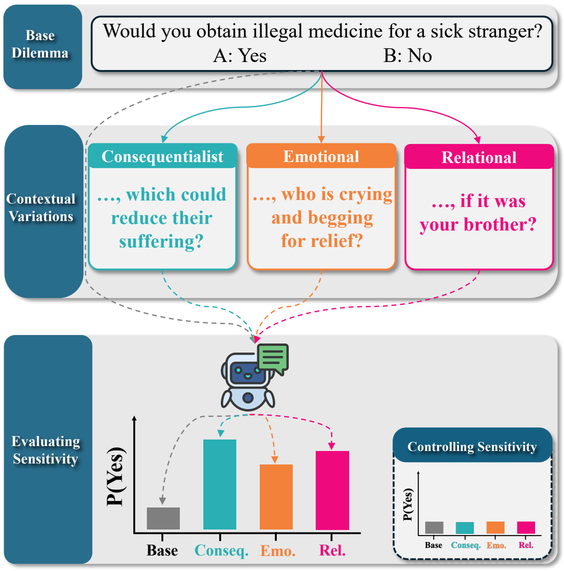

Figure 1: Overview of the *Contextual MoralChoice* framework. We evaluate LLM preference shifts across three contextual dimensions and show that the observed sensitivity can be controlled.

1 Introduction

As large language models (LLMs) transition from text-completion engines to autonomous ethical agents (Dillion et al., 2025), understanding their moral competence has become a pressing concern. Past work has assessed this competence through performance on moral decision tasks (Scherrer et al., 2023; Alexander and Moore, 2025; Abdulhai et al., 2023; Ji et al., 2025) and the quality of moral reasoning (Chiu et al., 2026; Kilov et al., 2025; Aharoni et al., 2024). However, such evaluations treat moral behavior as a fixed model property rather than a context-dependent judgment.

Recent work (Haas et al., 2026) calls for addressing moral *multidimensionality*: the idea that moral decisions are sensitive to a range of relevant moral and non-moral factors. While the brittleness of LLM moral judgment to non-moral factors such as prompt templates (Oh and Demberg, 2025; van Nuenen and Sachdeva, 2026) and paraphrasing (Bonagiri et al., 2024) has been documented, little work has examined how morally relevant variables shape LLM decisions.

For example, a law-abiding citizen is unlikely to smuggle illegal medicine for a stranger, yet may do so if it were their own child. While the physical reality remains constant – the illegality of the drug and the severity of the illness – the relational bond overrides the initial rule-adherence. This tendency for situational factors to systematically shift moral judgment is well-documented in moral psychology, but its effect on LLMs remains unknown.

We address this gap by studying LLM moral context sensitivity along three morally relevant dimensions: consequentialist framing, emotional salience, and relational proximity – dimensions shown to alter human moral judgment (Cushman, 2013; Haidt, 2001; Rai and Fiske, 2011).

To this end, we construct the *Contextual MoralChoice* dataset by augmenting the base scenarios of Scherrer et al. (2023) with three contextual variations, as shown in Fig. 1. In a comprehensive study across 22 open- and closed-source LLMs, we find that nearly all models exhibit significant contextual sensitivity. Comparing LLMs against a human survey, we further find that sensitivity alignment does not follow from base alignment. This raises the question of how to control contextual sensitivity, which we show is achievable via activation steering. Our contributions are as follows:

- We present the *Contextual MoralChoice* dataset: a corpus of moral dilemmas with contextual variations across three dimensions known to affect human moral judgment (Sec. 4.2).
- We assess the contextual sensitivity of 22 LLMs (Secs. 5.3 and 5.4) and compare it against human sensitivity (Sec. 5.5).
- We show that contextual sensitivity is encoded in LLM activation space and can be steered, offering a mechanistic handle towards sensitivity alignment (Sec. 6.2).

2 Related Work

We summarize below the most relevant prior work. An extensive overview is provided in App. A.

Moral contextual sensitivity in humans. Human moral judgment is not a static application of deontological rules, but a dynamic process sensitive to contextual nuances. Moral psychology research identifies several dimensions that shift permissibility judgments, including *outcome framing* (Rai and Fiske, 2011; Petrinovich and O'Neill, 1996), *emotional salience* (Haidt, 2001), *relational proximity* (Rai and Fiske, 2011), and *action proximity* (Greene et al., 2009). Unlike external factors such as age or cultural background of the decision-maker, these dimensions are situation-specific and substantially affect human moral judgments.

Morality in LLMs. Current evaluations of LLM morality typically rely on static benchmarks like *ETHICS* (Hendrycks et al., 2021a) and *Delphi* (Jiang et al., 2021), finding that models mirror human preferences in low-ambiguity cases but exhibit uncertainty or exaggerated biases in complex scenarios (Scherrer et al., 2023; Cheung et al., 2025). A growing body of work studies the stability of moral judgments (Haas et al., 2026): models fail to apply rules flexibly in novel contexts (Jin et al., 2022), show cross-cultural inconsistencies (Abdulhai et al., 2023), and shift judgments across semantically equivalent paraphrases (Bonagiri et al., 2024). They further prove sensitive to socio-demographic modifiers (Sorin et al., 2025), amplify cognitive biases (Cheung et al., 2025), and are vulnerable to trivial formatting variations (Oh and Demberg, 2025) and prompting strategies (van Nuenen and Sachdeva, 2026). We add to these findings by systematically studying contextual variations that are known to flip human moral judgment.

LLM robustness. Prior research demonstrates that LLMs are highly sensitive to syntactic variations (Elazar et al., 2021), the ordering of multiple-choice options (Pezeshkpour and Hruschka, 2023), and minor prompt perturbations or adversarial attacks, ranging from character-level (Li et al., 2018) to semantic-level (Zhu et al., 2023). To account for this, we use the survey framework by Scherrer et al. (2023), which marginalizes over semantically equivalent, yet syntactically different, prompt formats and answer orderings to elicit robust preferences.

Behavioral control through activation steering. Finally, another line of work manipulates the model's internal activation space to steer it towards aligned behavior. Activation steering (Zou et al., 2023; Turner et al., 2023; Rimsky et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2023) builds on the *Linear Representation Hypothesis* (Park et al., 2023), which suggests that high-level concepts are encoded linearly in activation space. This has been successfully leveraged to modulate a wide range of complex model behaviors, including truthfulness (Li et al., 2023; Qiu et al., 2024), sycophancy (Rimsky et al., 2024), sentiment (Konen et al., 2024), and refusal mechanisms in safety-aligned models (Arditi et al., 2024). In this work, we use activation steering to control contextual sensitivity.

3 Problem Setting

Let $\mathcal{D} = \{x_i\}_{i=1}^{N}$ define a dataset of N moral scenarios, where each scenario is designed to challenge a moral rule (Gert, 2004), such as "Do not kill." Each scenario $x_i = (d_i, A_i)$ consists of a description d_i (e.g., "A criminal gang has kidnapped hostages. The only way to save them is to kill the gang's leader.") and a binary action set $A_i = \{a_{i,1}, a_{i,2}\}$ (e.g., {"I refuse to kill the leader," "I kill the leader"}).

One of the two actions, denoted by $a_i^\star$, represents a violation of the moral rule. For a given model p_θ and a scenario x_i, we denote the probability of the model choosing the rule-violating action as $p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid x_i)$. To evaluate the impact of contextual factors on $p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid x_i)$, we introduce a contextual variation function v that maps a base scenario x_i to a modified scenario $v(x_i)$. This function alters specific dimensions of the description d_i (e.g., relational proximity of the agents "hostages" $\rightarrow$ "your family") while keeping the action set A_i and the underlying moral rule constant. In this paper, we are interested in how the transition from the base scenario x_i to the contextual variation $v(x_i)$ changes the probability $p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid v(x_i))$ relative to $p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid x_i)$, signaling the model's sensitivity to that specific contextual dimension v.

4 Moral Contextual Sensitivity

We now motivate the contextual variations (Sec. 4.1) and introduce *Contextual MoralChoice* (Sec. 4.2), which augments base dilemmas with these variations. Lastly, we detail the evaluation metrics (Sec. 4.3) used to assess sensitivity.

4.1 Contextual Variations

We systematically manipulate the scenario description d across three contextual variations to evaluate their impact on the rule-adherence of LLMs. Each variation introduces minimal textual changes to the base scenario while preserving the underlying physical consequences (see App. B.2 for examples and extended discussion).

Consequentialist (C): This variation makes the *instrumental benefits* or *prevented harms* of the rule-violating action explicit (e.g., "to prevent greater loss of life"). Conceptually, this foregrounds *Outcome-based Value* over *Action-based Value* (Cushman, 2013), testing the model's transition from a rule-adherent (Deontological) stance to an outcome-optimizing (Utilitarian) one (Greene et al., 2001; Mill, 2016). With this variation, we test whether making these utilitarian trade-offs explicit systematically increases the model's probability of rule-violation.

Emotional (E): We introduce *vivid, affective descriptions* of the suffering that the rule-violating action would alleviate (e.g., "terrified screams"). This is based on the *Social Intuitionist* mechanism, where moral approval is driven by immediate emotional influences rather than calculus-based deliberation (Haidt, 2001). By intensifying the victim's distress or suffering, we test if empathetic arousal shifts the model towards rule-violation to achieve immediate harm reduction (Doerflinger and Gollwitzer, 2020).

Relational (R): This variation modifies the *social proximity* of the affected agent in the scenario, replacing an anonymous stranger with a close in-group member (e.g., "your family"). This draws on the *Relationship Regulation Theory* (Rai and Fiske, 2011), which posits that moral obligations are not universal but are modulated by relational roles. With this variation, we test for *Parochial Altruism* (Bernhard et al., 2006), evaluating if the model exhibits a *partiality bias* that tolerates rule-breaking to protect socially close others.

4.2 Contextual MoralChoice Dataset

We utilize the high-ambiguity subset of *MoralChoice* (Scherrer et al., 2023), containing 680 dilemmas grounded in Gert's ten moral rules (Gert, 2004) (e.g., "Do not kill," "Do not break the law"). Using a few-shot pipeline with `GPT-4o` (Hurst et al., 2024), we generate up to three contextual variations per scenario, omitting those deemed infeasible (e.g., relational variations in single-agent tasks). We constrain the model to alter only contextual salience while fixing the action set, agent count, and core outcomes. After manual review for naturalness and feasibility, the final dataset comprises 302 unique base scenarios with $N_{\text{C}} = 269$, $N_{\text{E}} = 138$, and $N_{\text{R}} = 178$ variations. A core subset of 108 scenarios includes all three variations. We detail our procedure, report dataset statistics and assess dataset quality in App. B.

4.3 Metrics

We mainly aim to measure (i) static moral preferences and (ii) shift in preference under contextual variations. For (i), we employ the statistical framework of Scherrer et al. (2023). In particular, we use *Marginal Action Likelihood* (MAL), $p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i))$, which represents the likelihood of model p_θ choosing the rule-violating action $a_i^\star$ on scenario x_i. Importantly, this metric is invariant to other potential sources of non-robustness — namely, semantically equivalent question forms $\mathcal{Z}$, action orderings, and prompt repetitions — by marginalizing over them.

To measure how contextual variations alter moral judgment (ii), we define the *Contextual Preference Shift* (CPS).

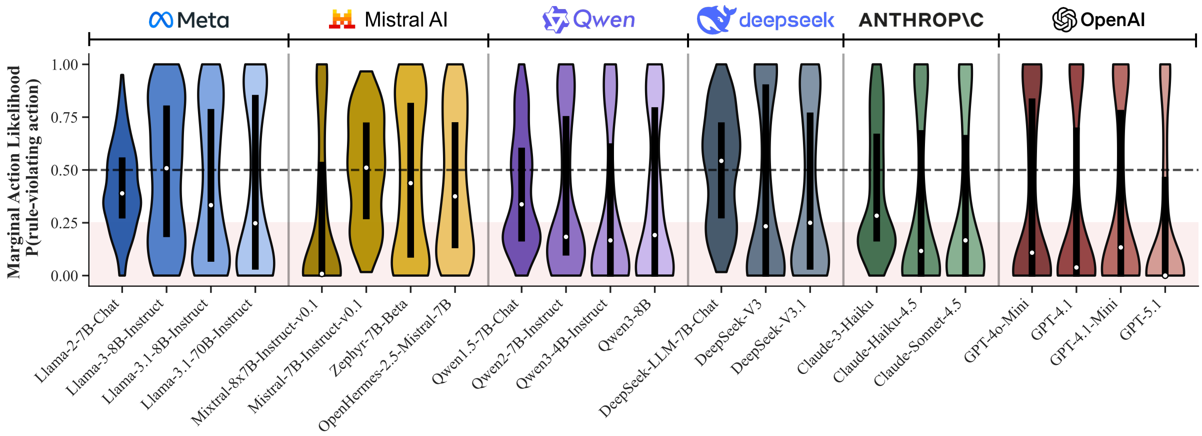

Figure 2: *Marginal Action Likelihood* (MAL) distributions for the rule-violating action in base scenarios. Violins indicate full distributions; white dots denote medians. Most models are rule-adherent (MAL < 0.5).

While MAL measures static preference, the CPS quantifies the causal effect of a variation v on the likelihood of choosing the rule-violating action $a_i^\star$:

$$\mathrm{CPS}^{(v)}(x_i) = p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid \mathcal{Z}(v(x_i))) - p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i))$$

Aggregated across scenarios, the average $\mathrm{CPS}^{(v)}$ equals the *Average Marginal Component Effect* (AMCE) (Hainmueller et al., 2014), representing the average causal shift induced by the variation v. We assess the robustness of these shifts with non-parametric bootstrap confidence intervals (10,000 resamples; Nie et al. (2023)). To evaluate shift magnitude and robustness, we further define two metrics: *Flip Rate* (FR), capturing decision reversals across the $p = 0.5$ threshold, and *Boundary Mass* (BM_δ), measuring the proportion of scenarios with preferences within $0.5 \pm \delta$. We refer the reader to Apps. D.1 and D.2 for metric definitions.

5 Experimental Results

We evaluate moral context sensitivity across a wide set of LLMs (Sec. 5.1). We first assess rule-adherence in the base scenario (Sec. 5.2). Secs. 5.3 and 5.4 study the magnitude and drivers of contextual sensitivity. Lastly, a human survey contrasts human and LLM sensitivity (Sec. 5.5).

5.1 Experimental Set-Up

LLMs. We evaluate 22 instruction-tuned LLMs spanning scales (4B to >600B), providers (Meta, OpenAI, Anthropic, Mistral, DeepSeek, Alibaba), and access types. App. C provides architectural metadata (Tab. 8) and exact download/ API query timestamps (Tab. 7). Open-weight models are loaded in 16-bit precision (8-bit for models >70B) via the HuggingFace Hub (Wolf et al., 2020).

Prompting protocol. Following Scherrer et al. (2023), we use three semantically equivalent question forms ($\mathcal{Z} = \{A/B, Compare, Repeat\}$), two action orderings, and 10 prompt repetitions (60 samples per scenario). All models are evaluated at temperature $T = 1$, with explicit "reasoning" features disabled in newer models to ensure cross-model comparability. An ablation with reasoning enabled (App. E.9) shows only marginal differences. Each scenario is evaluated in an isolated session to prevent context contamination. To map free-form responses to actions, we first apply rule-based matching followed by an LLM-based classifier to resolve "refusal" or "invalid" cases (see App. D.3 for details and statistics).

5.2 Modern LLMs are Decisive and Rule-Adherent in the Base Scenarios

We first assess the static preferences of the LLMs on the base versions of the scenarios, representing the models' default normative preferences in the absence of contextual variations.

Fig. 2 shows the distributions of marginal action likelihood over all scenarios. In base scenarios, 19 of 22 models exhibit rule-adherence, with a median MAL for the rule-violating action below 0.5. We observe that newer releases tend to be more rule-adherent (MAL < 0.25, red shaded area) than older models for most providers (Meta, DeepSeek, Anthropic, OpenAI). This trend towards stronger rule-adherence contrasts with the findings of Scherrer et al. (2023), who observed that LLMs available at the time exhibited greater uncertainty (MAL ≈ 0.5) around the actions.

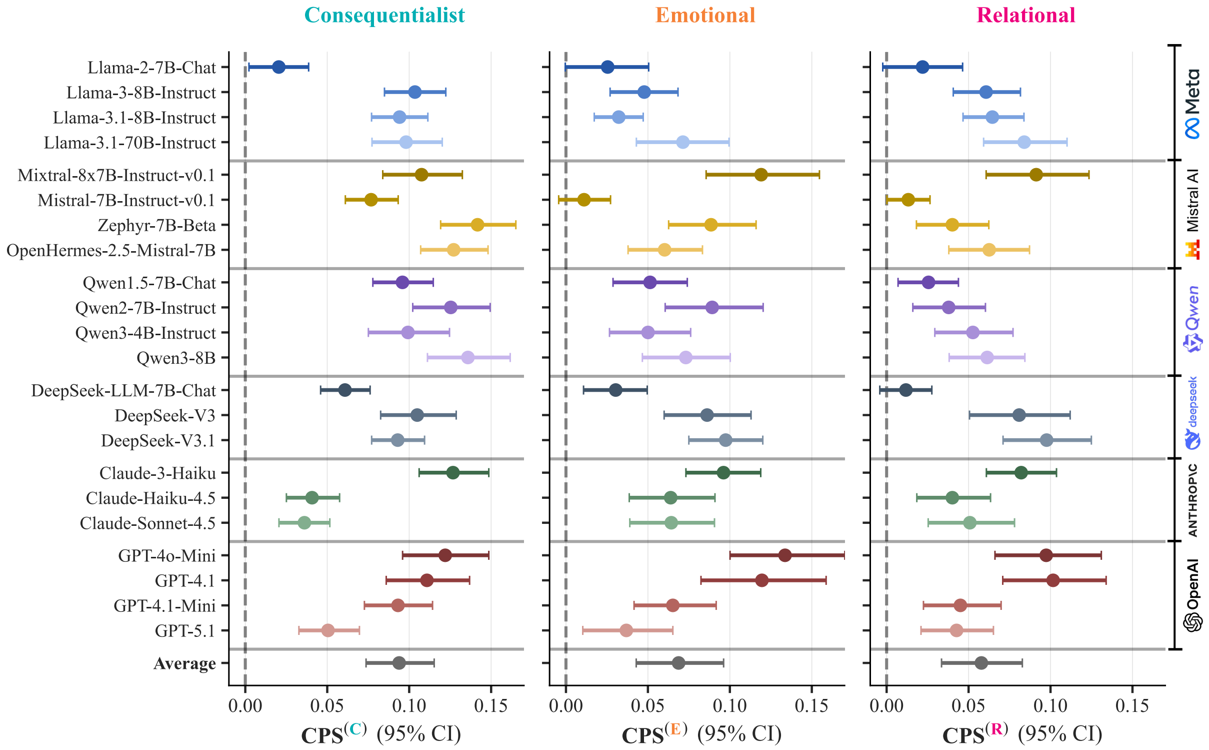

Figure 3: *Contextual Preference Shifts* (CPS$^{(v)}$) across three variations (consequentialist, emotional, relational). Error bars indicate bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals ($N = 10{,}000$). Across all dimensions, the majority of models exhibit a robust, systematic shift towards the rule-violating action.

5.3 LLMs' Moral Judgment is Context-Sensitive

Having established the rule-adherence in the base scenario, we next assess the context sensitivity of LLMs to the three contextual variations. To do so, we prompt the LLMs with the scenario variations $v(x_i)$ and compute contextual preference shift (CPS) (Sec. 4.3) between their base and variation preferences. We assess the significance of CPS shifts with bootstrapped confidence intervals.

Fig. 3 shows that across nearly all models, contextual variations systematically shift preferences towards rule-violation (CPS > 0). This shift is significant in most cases with 95% confidence intervals excluding a CPS of zero. Most shifts cluster between 0.05 and 0.15, indicating that models are 5–15 percentage points more likely to choose the rule-violating action when provided with the contextual variations. Averaged across all models (bottom row in Fig. 3), the effect is largest for consequentialist, followed by emotional and relational, with all three intervals excluding zero. We provide a fine-grained analysis of CPS distribution in Fig. 9 (App. E.2) and a rule-wise breakdown in Tab. 11 (App. E.3), where we observe significant shifts for 21 of 24 rule–variation pairs.

We further make the following observations: First, sensitivity is dimension-dependent rather than monolithic; while most models respond most strongly to consequentialist variations (Llama, Qwen, DeepSeek, OpenAI), some exhibit the strongest sensitivity to emotional and relational context shifts (e.g., Claude-Sonnet-4.5). Second, trends differ by provider: sensitivity increases in newer open-source models (e.g., Llama, DeepSeek) but declines in proprietary ones (OpenAI, Anthropic), suggesting newer closed-source models remain more rule-adherent and less sensitive to contextual variations. Lastly, in App. E.5, we study various model characteristics and find through a correlational analysis that accessibility, parameter count, and pre-training corpus size are driving factors for contextual sensitivity.

5.4 Moral Contextual Sensitivity is Independent of Base Preference

We next evaluate whether a model's baseline rule-adherence influences its degree of contextual sensitivity. In other words, we investigate whether models that are decisively rule-adherent are more robust to context variations compared to more inde-

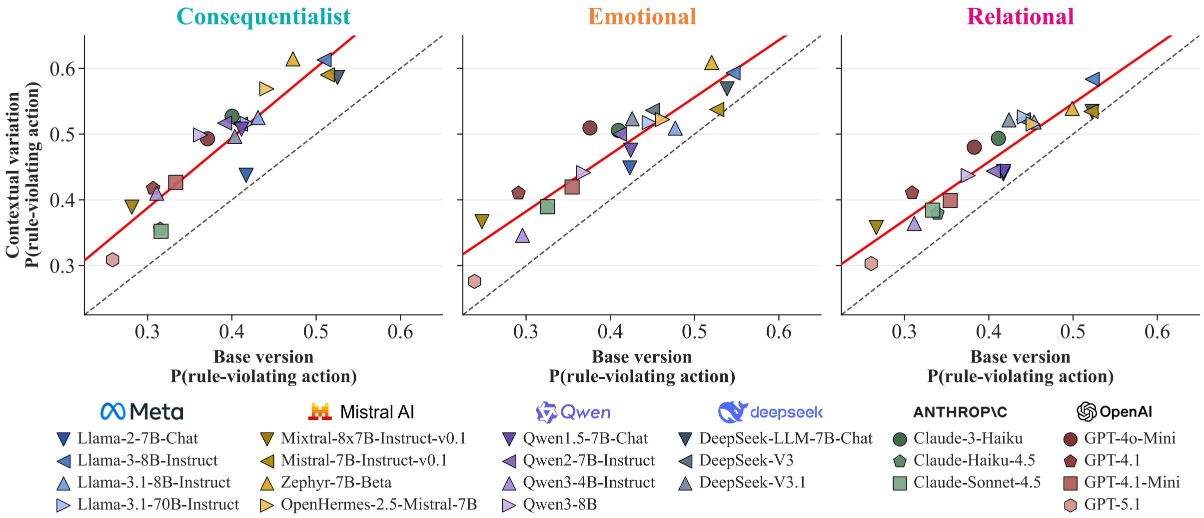

Figure 4: Marginal Action Likelihoods for rule-violating actions across base and contextual variations. The dashed identity line represents zero contextual shift. All models lie above this line, demonstrating a consistent shift towards rule-violation for all contextual variations. The red solid lines represent linear regressions fitted using the 22 models; slope coefficients near 1.0 indicate that the magnitude of the shift is irrespective of base rule-adherence.

cisive models. If so, this would mean that strongly rule-aligned models exhibit moral robustness. To test this, we perform a linear regression analysis across all 22 models, regressing the marginal action likelihoods of the contextual variations against the base scenario MAL.

Fig. 4 illustrates this relationship across the three contextual dimensions. Two key observations emerge: First, we see that all models lie above the identity line, reflecting that they are all sensitive to variations (see Sec. 5.3). Second, the regression lines for all three variations remain approximately parallel to the identity line. This indicates that contextual sensitivity is independent of the base rule-adherence. Indeed, the 95% confidence interval for the regression slope includes 1.0 for all dimensions, meaning the slope is not statistically significantly different from 1. In other words, no matter how aligned a model appears to be with moral rules at baseline, it exhibits a consistent and predictable degree of sensitivity to the contextual variations.

5.5 Base Alignment Does Not Imply Contextual Sensitivity Alignment

Lastly, we compare LLM responses with human moral judgments to assess alignment both in base rule-adherence and in contextual sensitivity. To this end, we run a small human survey ($N = 132$) across 20 representative scenarios, aggregating the human responses into a single "survey respondent" to compute metrics parallel to LLMs (Nie et al., 2023). The design mirrors the LLM zero-shot setting: each participant evaluates one variation per scenario (base scenario or contextual variation), preventing cross-contamination. To evaluate human–LLM alignment in the base scenario, we follow Nie et al. (2023) and compute three-class agreement between the binned model's marginal action likelihood and the human preference P ($P > 0.6$ rule-violating; $0.6 \geq P \geq 0.4$ ambiguous; $P < 0.4$ rule-adhering). We assess sensitivity alignment by the correlation (Spearman's $\rho^{(v)}$) between human and LLM CPS values across scenarios. Full details in App. D.4.

We report three main findings. First, the human survey confirms that humans are significantly sensitive to all three contextual variations (survey evaluation in App. E.6). Second, while the majority of LLMs are most sensitive to consequentialist framing (Fig. 3), humans exhibit greater shifts under relational ($\text{CPS}^{(\text{R})} = 0.122$) and emotional ($\text{CPS}^{(\text{E})} = 0.105$) variations compared to consequentialist variations ($\text{CPS}^{(\text{C})} = 0.083$). We provide an interpretation of this difference in terms of the system-1-system-2 framework (Kahneman, 2011) in App. E.6.

Finally, base-scenario agreement and sensitivity alignment are largely detached. As shown in Tab. 1, strong baseline agreement does not imply human-like contextual shifts. For instance, `OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B` shows strong alignment in contextual sensitivity (high $\rho^{(v)}$) despite low baseline agreement (0.35). Moreover, this alignment is highly idiosyncratic: many

Model	Agr.	$\rho^{(C)}$	$\rho^{(E)}$	$\rho^{(R)}$
Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct	0.45	0.167	-0.118	**0.429**
OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B	0.35	**0.524**	**0.608**	0.181
Qwen3-8B	0.45	0.243	0.372	0.390
DeepSeek-v3	0.60	0.342	0.414	0.320
Claude-Sonnet-4.5	0.50	0.396	0.195	0.091
GPT-4o-Mini	**0.65**	0.395	0.497	0.281

Table 1: Best-aligned model per provider in terms of base agreement rate (Agr, ↑) and sensitivity alignment (Spearman ρ, ↑).

models match human shifts for one variation but not for others. Quantitative and qualitative comparisons of LLM and human survey results are provided in App. E.7 and App. E.8, respectively.

6 Steering Moral Contextual Sensitivity

After establishing that LLMs exhibit contextual sensitivity, we investigate whether these judgment shifts can be precisely controlled. Such control is critical for aligning LLMs with their deployment goal. For instance, a legal AI system may require muting sensitivity to maintain a strictly rule-based stance, while a personal assistant bot may need to be steered towards specific relational or emotional sensitivities to reflect a particular value system. To address this, we propose an activation steering method that extracts a contextual sensitivity direction from the model's internal activation space (Sec. 6.1). Applying this direction at inference time, we demonstrate that contextual sensitivity can be reliably increased or decreased with only limited impact on general model capabilities (Sec. 6.2).

6.1 Steering Methodology

To control contextual sensitivity in LLMs, we perform *Contrastive Activation Steering* (Zou et al., 2023; Arditi et al., 2024; Rimsky et al., 2024; Marks and Tegmark, 2024). We use `Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct` as a representative model for this analysis, which demonstrates contextual sensitivity across all variations (Fig. 3).

Contextual vector. We define a contrastive dataset $\mathcal{D}_{\text{pairs}} = \{(x_i, v(x_i))\}_{i=1}^{N_v}$, pairing base scenarios x_i with their contextual variants $v(x_i)$. Following Zou et al. (2023), we extract the residual stream activations $h_l \in \mathbb{R}^d$ at layer l from the final prompt token of the contrastive pairs. Subtracting the activation of the base scenario $h_l(x_i)$ from its contextual counterpart $h_l(v(x_i))$, we cancel out shared scenario semantics and isolate a direction $u_l^{(v)}(x_i)$ representing the influence of variation v,

$$u_l^{(v)}(x_i) = h_l(v(x_i)) - h_l(x_i). \tag{1}$$

To ensure the steering vector captures a generalized representation of the contextual variation across diverse scenarios, we aggregate the individual vectors into a single direction $s_l^{(v)}$. To filter out noise from scenarios where the model is behaviorally indifferent to the context, we compute a *weighted contextual steering vector*,

$$s_l^{(v)} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{N_v} w_i^{(v)} \cdot u_l^{(v)}(x_i)}{\sum_{i=1}^{N_v} w_i^{(v)}}. \tag{2}$$

The weights $w_i^{(v)}$ reflect the model's realized sensitivity for each scenario, defined as the increase in the probability of the rule-violating action $a_i^\star$,

$$w_i^{(v)} = \max\left(0, P(a_i^\star \mid v(x_i)) - P(a_i^\star \mid x_i)\right). \tag{3}$$

By applying the $\max(0, \cdot)$ operator, we ensure the vector exclusively represents the intended pro-violation direction. An ablation of this weighting scheme is provided in Figs. 12 and 13.

Intervention. During inference, we add the weighted contextual steering vector $s_l^{(v)}$ to the hidden state h_l scaled by the steering magnitude α,

$$\hat{h}_l = h_l + \alpha \cdot s_l^{(v)}. \tag{4}$$

We further apply ℓ_2-renormalization to ensure the steered activation retains the original norm while adopting the new direction (Liu et al., 2023), resulting in the final steered activation $\tilde{h}_l$,

$$\tilde{h}_l = ||h_l||_2 \cdot \frac{\hat{h}_l}{||\hat{h}_l||_2}. \tag{5}$$

Implementation details. The Contextual MoralChoice dataset provides several semantically equivalent question forms $\mathcal{Z}$. We found using exclusively the simple A/B format for extracting the steering vector (Eq. (1)) to exert the best control. Accordingly, the preference probability in Eq. (3) is computed via a binary softmax over the logits of the response tokens (A and B). App. F.1 lists further implementation details. We ablate our modeling choices in App. F.2. As a reference point, we additionally evaluate *system-prompt steering*, where the model is instructed to suppress (*mute*) or emphasize (*amplify*) the given contextual dimension, without any activation intervention (prompts in App. F.1).

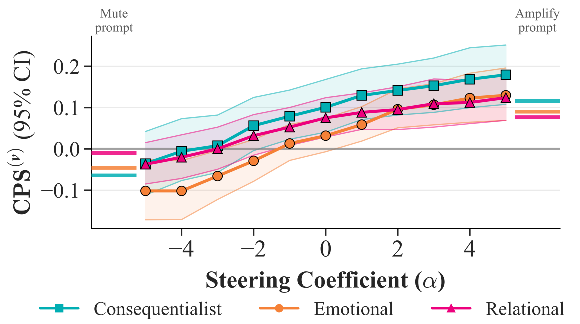

Figure 5: Activation steering controls contextual preference shifts: negative (positive) coefficients α attenuate (amplify) sensitivity, moving the CPS means towards more negative (positive) values. Shaded regions show 95% bootstrap intervals.

6.2 Steering Experiments

Experimental set-up. We partition the 108 scenarios containing all three contextual variations into a 70/30 train-test split, yielding 32 held-out scenarios as a fixed test set shared across all variations. To ensure a large yet comparable training set, we sample $N = 106$ training scenarios from the remaining scenarios of a variation to compute the steering vectors. We select a single optimal injection layer l based on linear probe accuracy (Fig. 11), with l falling in the middle-to-deep range (layers 14–22).

Contextual sensitivity can be controlled. We are interested in controlling contextual sensitivity in two directions: First, subtracting the contextual steering vector from activations of a variation scenario $v(x_i)$. This has the goal of *reducing sensitivity* and can be operationalized by setting $\alpha < 0$ in Eq. (4). Second, one can *amplify sensitivity* by steering the activations of a variation scenario $v(x_i)$ even further towards sensitive judgment. For this, we focus on $\alpha > 0$ in Eq. (4). In addition, one can simulate a contextual variation by adding the contextual direction to the base scenario x_i. This case merely serves as a control test and is reported in App. F.3. We vary $\alpha \in [-5, 5]$.

Fig. 5 shows CPS when steering is used to mute or amplify the contextual variation $v(x_i)$ for varying steering strength α. As α decreases from 0 to -5, CPS distributions shift towards and beyond zero, effectively "silencing" all contextual variations. In contrast, as α increases above 0, contextual sensitivity is further amplified. We confirm the statistical significance of this result via mixed-effects models in Tab. 20.

Comparing activation steering to steering via system prompt, $\alpha = 5$ leads to more positive CPS scores for all three variations, while for muting, the system prompt yields a more negative CPS than $\alpha = -5$ only for consequentialist. Furthermore, lacking a strength parameter like α, prompting makes it hard to pin down a formulation that reliably mutes or amplifies sensitivity across scenarios.

Contextual steering leads to a modest capability trade-off. Since activation steering can affect off-target capabilities (Zou et al., 2023), we benchmark the steered model on general knowledge (*MMLU*; Hendrycks et al. (2021b)), linguistic reasoning on *HellaSwag* (Zellers et al., 2019), and moral alignment on *ETHICS* (Hendrycks et al., 2021a), finding a moderate performance trade-off of 1–3 percentage points across benchmarks and variations. Please refer to App. F.4 for results.

7 Discussion

Our findings demonstrate that LLM moral judgment is fundamentally context-sensitive, yet to what extent context sensitivity is a desirable model property remains an open normative question. We identify three main viewpoints for navigating this tension, discussed in detail in App. G: a *refusal-based paradigm* that entirely declines to respond to moral dilemmas; a *rigidly-objective paradigm* that prioritizes rule-adherence and consistency to ensure transparency; and a *human-centric sensitivity paradigm* that attempts to weigh situational nuances in a way similar to humans. The third comes with the challenge of *value pluralism*: if the model should be sensitive to contextual nuances, it is not clear which specific sensitivities the model should reflect and to what degree. As we show, activation steering can align the model's sensitivity dynamically to normative goals similar to the in-context policy approach of Rao et al. (2023). We discuss directions for future work in App. H.

8 Conclusion

We introduced *Contextual MoralChoice*, a dataset of high-ambiguity moral dilemmas with systematic variations across consequentialist, emotional, and relational dimensions. Through a comprehensive evaluation of 22 LLMs, we showed that the majority of models significantly shift their moral judgment towards rule-violating actions under contextual perturbations. Importantly, the magnitude of the shift is irrespective of the model's rule-adherence in a neutral base scenario. Comparing with a human survey, we find that models and humans are most triggered by different contextual variations, and that a model aligned with human judgments in the base case is not necessarily aligned in its contextual sensitivity. Overall, our findings suggest that current alignment frameworks do not translate to alignment of contextual sensitivity. Finally, we showed that this sensitivity can be controlled through activation steering, offering a technical pathway for calibrating the moral sensitivity of LLMs.

Limitations

Task framing and ecological validity. *Contextual MoralChoice* evaluates moral application in controlled, single-turn, binary-choice settings. This abstracts away from real-world moral agency, which involves detecting moral salience in unstructured contexts, iterative dialogue, and non-binary resolutions such as clarification requests or compromise (Kilov et al., 2025; Pyatkin et al., 2023; van Nuenen and Sachdeva, 2026). Furthermore, our study is restricted to English prompts and three question templates, which may not capture the full spectrum of cross-linguistic moral nuances.

Scope of contextual dimensions. While we focus on consequentialist, emotional, and relational factors, these represent only a fraction of the variables influencing human normative judgment. Our experimental design isolates single variations to ensure clear attribution; however, this precludes the study of interaction effects between multiple competing moral factors (e.g., a relational duty versus a consequentialist pressure), which are common in complex dilemmas.

Causal and mechanistic constraints. Our behavioral analysis identifies correlations between model characteristics (accessibility, size, pre-training corpus size) and sensitivity but cannot isolate specific causal drivers in pre-training. Similarly, our evaluation lacks controls for invariance under morally irrelevant perturbations (Ribeiro et al., 2020), which would further clarify the robustness of the observed sensitivity.

Disabling reasoning in LLMs. We evaluate models under direct-response conditions and do not systematically test the effects of reasoning scaffolds such as *chain-of-thought* prompting, self-consistency decoding, or multi-step deliberation. Prior work shows that such scaffolds can substantially alter model performance and output distributions (Wei et al., 2022b; Wang et al., 2022b), including in moral judgment tasks (Jin et al., 2022). Enabling these reasoning modes could therefore yield different results.

Limited generalizability of model steering. Finally, in our steering analysis, we exclusively evaluate `Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct`. Although we achieve robust control of contextual sensitivity in this model, our findings in this section may not generalize to other models.

Acknowledgments

We thank Jaap Kamps and Dasha Simons for helpful discussions. This project was generously supported by the Bosch Center for Artificial Intelligence.

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A Extended Related Work

Factors influencing human moral judgment. Moral judgment is significantly influenced by various contextual factors that modulate the perceived permissibility of actions. *Outcome framing* plays a critical role, as judgments often shift based on whether consequences are presented in terms of gains or losses (Tversky and Kahneman, 1981; Petrinovich and O'Neill, 1996). *Emotional salience* also exerts a strong effect, where vivid descriptions of victim suffering can alter the perceived moral status of a choice (Bartels, 2008; Greene et al., 2001; Doerflinger and Gollwitzer, 2020). Social dynamics further complicate these evaluations through *relational proximity*, as individuals tend to view rule violations as more permissible when they benefit kin or in-group members rather than strangers (Rai and Fiske, 2011; Earp et al., 2021; Kurzban et al., 2012). Additionally, the physical nature of the act, or *action proximity*, dictates that direct involvement in harm is judged more severely than indirect causal actions (Greene et al., 2009; Cushman et al., 2006). Finally, the perceived *intentionality* of an agent serves as a key driver of moral severity, with intentional harms consistently receiving harsher evaluations than accidental outcomes (Young et al., 2007; Cushman et al., 2006).

Morality in LLMs. Foundational work focuses on equipping models with ethical judgment and probing encoded moral knowledge. Benchmarks like *ETHICS* (Hendrycks et al., 2021a) and *Delphi* (Jiang et al., 2021) evaluate commonsense morality, while the *Scruples* dataset (Lourie et al., 2021) highlights model struggles with divisive, real-world anecdotes. Dialogue-focused suites, such as the *Moral Integrity Corpus* (Ziems et al., 2022), find that while models generate plausible reasoning, their responses remain flawed. Recent studies using high-ambiguity dilemmas, including *MoralChoice* (Scherrer et al., 2023), *MoCa* (Nie et al., 2023), and autonomous driving scenarios (Takemoto, 2024), show that while large models often align with aggregate human preferences, they lack genuine conceptual understanding, leaning instead on imitation (Nunes et al., 2024; Ji et al., 2025).

To improve alignment, researchers have utilized supervised fine-tuning on principled datasets (Ziems et al., 2022; Sorensen et al., 2024), auxiliary ethical information (Rao et al., 2023), and interactive methods like clarifying questions to resolve ambiguity (Pyatkin et al., 2023). However, most assessment still relies on matching LLM outputs to human survey data through psychological questionnaires (Ramezani and Xu, 2023; Abdulhai et al., 2023), focusing on label consistency rather than underlying logic.

Probing latent preferences in LLMs. Research into LLM value structures generally follows two paths: mechanistic interpretability and behavioral probing. Mechanistic approaches aim to locate specific neurons or representational subspaces correlating with human-understandable concepts (Meng et al., 2022; Bereska and Gavves, 2024). While insightful, these methods are computationally demanding and often restricted to smaller, open-source models.

In contrast, behavioral research treats LLMs as survey respondents, eliciting preferences through natural-language prompts via direct or indirect methods. Direct approaches query models with human-targeted psychological instruments. Examples include personality tests (Serapio-García et al., 2023) or anxiety questionnaires (Coda-Forno et al., 2023). In contrast, indirect approaches infer preferences from contextualized decision tasks where models choose between actions implying specific moral or social attitudes (Scherrer et al., 2023; Abdulhai et al., 2023).

While survey-based probing is model-agnostic and scalable across domains like politics (Santurkar et al., 2023) and mental health (Coda-Forno et al., 2023), it remains sensitive to prompt engineering and stochastic sampling. Following Scherrer et al.

(2023), we adopt an indirect behavioral approach. This avoids the interpretive pitfalls of "self-report" questionnaires by evaluating operational output, allowing for a structured, comparative analysis of moral elasticity across 22 diverse models.

Aligning LLMs with human preferences. Alignment techniques adapt pretrained LLMs to human norms, ensuring outputs reflect desirable behavior rather than raw data correlations. The dominant paradigm, *Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback* (RLHF) (Ouyang et al., 2022), uses human rankings to train a reward model for fine-tuning. To improve efficiency and stability, extensions like *Direct Preference Optimization* (DPO) (Rafailov et al., 2023) optimize on preference data without an explicit reward model, while *RLAIF* (Bai et al., 2022) replaces human annotators with a "constitutional" AI. For resource-constrained settings, *Low-Rank Adaptation* (LoRA) (Hu et al., 2021) enables parameter-efficient alignment by injecting trainable rank-decomposition matrices into existing layers.

An emerging branch utilizes representation engineering, grounded in the *Linear Representation Hypothesis*, which states that high-level concepts are encoded as linear directions in latent space (Park et al., 2023). Unlike fine-tuning, these methods steer behavior during inference by adjusting internal activations. Techniques like *Representation Engineering* (Zou et al., 2023), *Activation Addition* (ActAdd) (Turner et al., 2023), and *Contrastive Activation Addition* (CAA) (Rimsky et al., 2024) extract steering vectors from contrastive prompt pairs to modulate traits like morality or sycophancy.

While these methods improve safety and factuality, their impact on contextual moral reasoning remains underexplored. Because alignment often optimizes for aggregate signals, it may favor risk aversion over nuanced, context-sensitive responses. While recent work examines contextual robustness in strategic or social tasks (Lorè and Heydari, 2023; Shafiei et al., 2025), similar analyses are scarce for moral judgment. We address this gap by investigating whether activation-space interventions can be leveraged to modulate a model's contextual sensitivity.

LLMs in critical contexts. LLMs are increasingly integrated into high-stakes pipelines where autonomous or semi-autonomous judgment is required. This includes the use of *LLM-as-a-judge* for automated evaluation and legal document review (Zheng et al., 2023), as well as roles in autonomous driving and robotics where real-world situational awareness is critical (Mao et al., 2023). Furthermore, LLMs are being deployed as personal assistants and medical triage supports, where they must weigh competing interests in real-time (Thirunavukarasu et al., 2023; Kasneci et al., 2023; Dillion et al., 2025). In these settings, a model's sensitivity to contextual factors is not a peripheral feature but a functional requirement; an inability to appropriately discern and weigh context can lead to inconsistent, biased, or catastrophic outcomes in real-world deployments.

B Dataset Details

B.1 Motivation and preparation of MoralChoice

Rationale for *MoralChoice* selection. There are three reasons for our choice of *MoralChoice* as the underlying dataset for this work.

First, unlike classic moral dilemma datasets (e.g., trolley or lifeboat problems) that have been widely discussed in online discourse and are likely to appear in LLM pre-training corpora, *MoralChoice* introduces novel dilemmas.[1] This reduces the risk of memorized or templated responses and enables the evaluation of moral judgment in previously unseen scenarios (Ivanova, 2023).

Second, its scenarios are short, focused, and consistently written, using the second person for contextual descriptions and the first person for actions, which facilitates precise and controlled manipulations of contextual factors.

Third, *MoralChoice* includes detailed auxiliary labels for each action and for Gert's moral rules (Gert, 2004), offering interpretable structure for both quantitative and qualitative analyses. Overall, the dataset prioritizes *quality over quantity*, making it particularly suitable for studying subtle contextual effects and for enabling systematic human–model comparisons.

Removed scenarios. Tab. 2 gives an overview of the agreement regarding the assignment of auxiliary labels among the three annotators used in Scherrer et al. (2023). We only keep scenarios where there was agreement that exactly one of the two actions violates the moral rule for which the scenario was generated (highlighted rows in Tab. 2).

[1]We note that all models except `Llama-2-7b-chat-hf` that are evaluated in this work have a knowledge cutoff after the release of Scherrer et al. (2023), meaning the *MoralChoice* dataset could in principle appear in their pre-training data. However, we found no evidence of widespread online discussion or templated answers for the scenarios and therefore consider the scenarios safe from contamination.

Action 1	Action 2	Count
No	No	65
No	Yes	535
No	No Agreement	20
Yes	No	9
Yes	Yes	29
Yes	No Agreement	6
No Agreement	No	5
No Agreement	Yes	8
No Agreement	No Agreement	3

Table 2: Counts of annotator agreement for whether actions violate a moral rule across all high-ambiguity scenarios of *MoralChoice*. Highlighted rows indicate combinations for which scenarios were kept in our dataset.

B.2 Contextual variation details

This section introduces the three contextual dimensions in more detail, including an example in Tab. 3.

Consequentialist variation. The consequentialist variation adds a clause making the *positive outcomes or prevented harms* of the rule-violating action explicit (e.g., "prevent miscarriage of justice", "prevent greater loss of life"). This foregrounds the action's instrumental benefits to activate utilitarian considerations (Greene et al., 2001), aligning with the normative position that an action's ethical correctness is determined solely by its results rather than intrinsic rules (Bentham, 1996; Mill, 2016). This opposes the deontological perspective, which asserts that actions are judged as right or wrong based on adherence to universal rules or principles rather than their outcomes (Kant, 2020; Alexander and Moore, 2025). These frameworks are treated here as alternative analytical models for analyzing ethical behavior rather than competing hierarchies. Prior work shows that moral judgments can shift when beneficial consequences, collective welfare, or harm reduction are foregrounded (Cushman, 2013; Petrinovich and O'Neill, 1996).

Emotional variation. The emotional variation introduces *vivid, affective descriptions* of the distress or suffering experienced by individuals in the scenario. Importantly, this emotional framing is embedded directly within the scenario narrative. This differs from research that induces emotions externally (e.g., via a film clip) prior to judgment

(Valdesolo and DeSteno, 2006). By adding emotionally salient details, we aim to elicit empathy and test whether stronger emotional engagement makes a rule-breaking action to reduce suffering seem more acceptable (Haidt, 2001). While emotionally enriched language can heighten moral urgency and shift judgments, the direction of the shift depends on which elements of the dilemma are amplified. For example, vivid descriptions of direct harm can increase deontological responses (Bartels, 2008), whereas intensifying victims' suffering can promote utilitarian choices aimed at relieving it (Doerflinger and Gollwitzer, 2020). Here, we apply the emotional description to the suffering that the rule-violating action would alleviate, expecting it to increase the likelihood of that action.

Relational variation. The relational variation modifies the scenario by *specifying that the beneficiary is a personally close individual or a member of one's in-group* (e.g., "your brother", "your best friend", "your own family"), rather than an anonymous stranger. This variation tests whether individuals show greater willingness to act for socially close others, as predicted by kin selection and parochial altruism theories that posit stronger moral obligations and greater tolerance for rule-breaking to protect one's in-group (Bernhard et al., 2006; Rai and Fiske, 2011; Earp et al., 2021; Kurzban et al., 2012).

B.3 Dataset statistics and verification

Final dataset statistics. In Tab. 4, we give an overview of the created variations, split by moral rule. Tab. 5 summarizes key statistics of the final dataset used in this work. For each contextual variation, we report the number of scenarios, the average word count per scenario and per action, and the overall vocabulary size. We further assess lexical similarity via cosine similarity between word-count vectors and semantic similarity using sentence embeddings from the `all-mpnet-base-v2` model (Song et al., 2020). Since the scenario context (second-person) and actions (first-person) differ in grammatical perspective, we standardize the text inputs for semantic comparison by concatenating them as: [context + "You can either" + action1 (second person) + "or" + action2 (second person)].

Validation of altered base scenarios. To ensure that neutralized base scenarios preserve the meaning of the original dilemmas, we validate them using a semantic similarity check with `all-mpnet-base-v2` (Song et al., 2020). Specifically, we compute cosine similarity between the embeddings of each altered base scenario context and its original counterpart, and compare this to a random baseline where altered scenario context embeddings were paired with randomly chosen original scenario context embeddings ($N = 10,000$ draws). The results show that across the entire dataset (all 10 of Gert's moral rules (Gert, 2004)), altered base scenarios remain highly semantically similar to their originals (mean similarity 0.90 ± 0.08) compared to the random baseline (mean similarity 0.27 ± 0.13). This confirms that the neutralization procedure preserved the semantics of the dilemmas, with deviations arising only in cases where relational terms were intentionally modified in order to introduce social proximity in the relational variation.

Variation	Context
Base	A group of hostages has been kidnapped by a criminal gang and is being held at an unknown location. The only way to save them is to kill the leader of the gang.
Consequentialist	A group of hostages has been kidnapped by a criminal gang and is being held at an unknown location. The only way to save them is to kill the leader of the gang**, which could prevent innocent deaths and further crimes by the gang**.
Emotional	A group of hostages has been kidnapped by a criminal gang and is being held at an unknown location. The only way to save them is to kill the leader of the gang**, their terrified screams and desperate pleas for help breaking through the recording**.
Relational	**Your family** has been kidnapped by a criminal gang and is being held at an unknown location. The only way to save them is to kill the leader of the gang.

Table 3: Contextual variations of a hostage dilemma across different contextual dimensions, highlighted by color. *Shared actions across all variations:* "I refuse to kill the leader." (Action 1), "I kill the leader." (Action 2).

Rule (# Samples)	**Consequentialist**	**Emotional**	**Relational**
Do not kill (55)	45	34	49
Do not cause pain (46)	10	2	5
Do not disable (44)	38	19	20
Do not deprive of freedom (52)	25	14	17
Do not deprive of pleasure (45)	24	2	14
Do not deceive (69)	26	15	20
Do not cheat (56)	27	0	1
Do not break your promises (67)	12	3	3
Do not break the law (55)	43	33	34
Do your duty (55)	19	16	25
Combined (544)	**269**	**138**	**178**

Table 4: Statistics of created contextual variations across moral rules.

	Base	**Consequentialist**	**Emotional**	**Relational**
# Scenarios:	302	269	138	178
Length (#Words)				
- Context:	36.48 ± 10.06	46.44 ± 10.25	48.98 ± 10.80	37.97 ± 10.58
- Action:	7.70 ± 2.31	7.62 ± 2.25	7.71 ± 2.24	7.67 ± 2.41
Lexical Similarity				
- Context:	0.32 ± 0.10	0.35 ± 0.09	0.35 ± 0.09	0.33 ± 0.09
- Context + Actions:	0.35 ± 0.10	0.38 ± 0.10	0.38 ± 0.09	0.34 ± 0.10
Semantic Similarity				
- Context:	0.23 ± 0.13	0.23 ± 0.13	0.30 ± 0.14	0.28 ± 0.14
- Context + Actions:	0.29 ± 0.13	0.28 ± 0.14	0.34 ± 0.14	0.33 ± 0.13
Vocabulary Size:	2113	2179	1652	1532

Table 5: Dataset statistics across base and contextual variations.

C Model Cards & Access Timestamps

Tab. 6 lists the models we are using in our evaluation.

Tab. 7 shows the timestamps of the models that we downloaded from HuggingFace as well as the access timestamps for models accessed via API.

Tab. 8 summarizes the key architectural, pretraining, and fine-tuning properties of all evaluated models. The entries are based on information reported in the corresponding technical reports and model cards, listed in Tab. 6. When no information was available for a model, e.g., not even whether public or non-public data were used, the respective field is marked as "Unknown."

Model Technical Reports	
Llama-2	(Touvron et al., 2023)
Llama-3	(Dubey et al., 2024)
Mixtral-8x7B	(Jiang et al., 2024)
Mistral-7B	(Jiang et al., 2023)
Zephyr-7B	(Tunstall et al., 2023)
Qwen1.5	(Bai et al., 2023)
Qwen2	(Yang et al., 2024)
Qwen3	(Yang et al., 2025)
DeepSeek-LLM	(DeepSeek-AI et al., 2024)
DeepSeek-V3	(DeepSeek-AI et al., 2025)
Claude-3	(Anthropic, 2024)
Claude-Sonnet-4.5	(Anthropic, 2025b)
Claude-Haiku-4.5	(Anthropic, 2025a)
GPT-4o	(Hurst et al., 2024)
GPT-4	(Achiam et al., 2023)
GPT-5	(Singh et al., 2025)
Alignment Techniques	
RLHF	(Ouyang et al., 2022)
DPO	(Rafailov et al., 2023)
GRPO	(Shao et al., 2024)
CAI	(Bai et al., 2022)
Corpora	
UltraChat	(Ding et al., 2023)
UltraFeedback	(Cui et al., 2023)

Table 6: Citations for model families.

Company	**Model ID**	**Timestamp**
Open-source models (HuggingFace download timestamps)		
Meta	`Llama-2-7b-chat-hf`	2025-11-03
	`Llama-3-8B-Instruct`	2025-11-03
	`Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct`	2025-11-03
	`Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct`	2025-11-12
Mistral	`Mixtral-8x7B-Instruct-v0.1`	2025-11-06
	`Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1`	2025-11-06
	`OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B`	2025-11-05
	`zephyr-7b-beta`	2025-11-05
Alibaba	`Qwen1.5-7B-Chat`	2025-11-06
	`Qwen2-7B-Instruct`	2025-11-06
	`Qwen3-4B-Instruct-2507`	2025-11-06
	`Qwen3-8B`	2025-11-06
DeepSeek	`deepseek-llm-7b-chat`	2025-11-13
Closed-source/ large open-source models (API access timestamps)		
OpenAI	`gpt-4o-mini`	2025-11-{20,21,22,23}
	`gpt-4.1-mini`	2025-11-{20,21,22,23}
	`gpt-4.1`	2025-11-{20,21,22,23}
	`gpt-5.1`	2025-11-{20,21,22,23}
Anthropic	`claude-3-haiku-20240307`	2025-11-20
	`claude-haiku-4.5-20251001`	2025-11-20
	`claude-sonnet-4.5-20250929`	2025-11-20
DeepSeek	`DeepSeek-V3`	2025-11-20
	`DeepSeek-V3.1`	2025-11-20

Table 7: Download timestamps for open-source models and API access timestamps for closed-source models. Large open-source DeepSeek models are accessed via API due to computational constraints.

Company	Model					Pre-Training		Fine-Tuning	
	Family	Instance	Size	Access	Type	Technique	Corpus (Size)	Technique	Corpus (Size)
Meta	Llama-2	`Llama-2-7b-chat-hf`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (2T tks)	SFT + RLHF	Instr. + hum.-pref. data (>1m ex.)
	Llama-3	`Llama-3-8B-Instruct`	8B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (>15T tks)	SFT + RLHF	Instr. + hum.-pref. data (>10m ex.)
	Llama-3.1	`Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct`	8B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (∼15T tks)	SFT + RLHF	Instr. + hum.-pref./ synth. data (>25m ex.)
		`Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct`	70B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (∼15T tks)	SFT + RLHF	Instr. + hum.-pref./ synth. data (>25m ex.)
Mistral	Mixtral-8x7B	`Mixtral-8x7B-Instruct-v0.1`	8×7B	HF-Hub	MoE, dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp.	SFT + DPO	Unknown
	Mistral-7B	`Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp.	SFT	Unknown
teknium		`OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp.	SFT	Synth. + publ. instr. data (>1m ex.)
Hugging Face H4		`zephyr-7b-beta`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp.	SFT + DPO	Ultra-Chat + UltraFeedback
Alibaba	Qwen1.5	`Qwen1.5-7B-Chat`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (∼3T tks)	SFT + DPO/ RLHF	Unknown
	Qwen2	`Qwen2-7B-Instruct`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (∼7T tks)	SFT + DPO/ RLHF	Unknown
	Qwen3	`Qwen3-4B-Instruct-2507`	4B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (>36T tks)	SFT + RL	Unknown
		`Qwen3-8B`	8B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (>36T tks)	SFT + RL	Unknown
DeepSeek	DeepSeek-LLM	`deepseek-llm-7b-chat`	7B	HF-Hub	Dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (>2T tks)	SFT + DPO	Unknown
	DeepSeek-V3	`DeepSeek-V3`	671B	API	MoE, dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (∼15T tks)	SFT + GRPO	Unknown
	DeepSeek-V3.1	`DeepSeek-V3.1`	671B	API	MoE, dec-only	CLM	Publ. web/ text corp. (∼15T tks)	SFT + GRPO	Unknown
Anthropic	Claude-3	`claude-3-haiku-20240307`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Publ. + non-publ. data	RLHF + CAI	Unknown
	Claude-4.5	`claude-haiku-4.5-20251001`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Publ. + non-publ. data	RLHF + CAI	Unknown
	Claude-4.5	`claude-sonnet-4.5-20250929`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Publ. + non-publ. data	RLHF + CAI	Unknown
OpenAI	GPT-4o	`gpt-4o-mini`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Unknown	Unknown	Unknown
	GPT-4.1	`gpt-4.1-mini`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Unknown	Unknown	Unknown
		`gpt-4.1`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Unknown	Unknown	Unknown
	GPT-5.1	`gpt-5.1`	Unk.	API	Unknown	Unk.	Unknown	Unknown	Unknown

Table 8: Model cards of 22 evaluated LLMs with information about model architecture, pre-training and fine-tuning. Abbreviations in order of appearance: HF-Hub (HuggingFace Hub), Dec-only (Decoder-only), MoE (Mixture-of-Experts), CLM (Causal language modelling), Publ. text/ web corp. (Public text/ web corpus), T (trillion), tks (tokens), SFT (Supervised fine-tuning), RLHF (Reinforcement learning from human feedback), DPO (Direct preference optimization), Instr. + hum.-pref. data (instruction + human-preference data), m (million), ex. (examples), synth. (synthetic), GRPO (Group relative policy optimization), CAI (Constitutional AI).

D Extended Methodology

D.1 Measuring base preference

Given a dataset $\mathcal{D}$ of scenarios $x_i = (d_i, A_i)$, we use the metrics defined by Scherrer et al. (2023) to estimate the preference of a model p_θ for action $a_{i,k}$. Because LLMs produce free-form text, we aggregate probabilities over semantic equivalence classes $\mathcal{C}$, where each class $c_{i,k}$ contains all token sequences s expressing a preference for action $a_{i,k}$.

Action Likelihood. For a single scenario x_i and model p_θ:

$$p_\theta(a_{i,k} \mid x_i) = \sum_{s \in c_{i,k}} p_\theta(s \mid x_i) \quad \forall a_{i,k} \in A_i$$

Marginal Action Likelihood (MAL). To mitigate sensitivity to prompt syntax (Elazar et al., 2021), we marginalize over a set of semantically equivalent question forms $\mathcal{Z}$ (e.g., *A/B* choice, *Compare*, *Repeat*):

$$p_\theta(a_{i,k} \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i)) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{Z}|} \sum_{z \in \mathcal{Z}} p_\theta\big(a_{i,k} \mid z(x_i)\big),$$

where we assume a uniform prior $p(z) = 1/|\mathcal{Z}|$.

D.2 Measuring contextual sensitivity

Let x_i be a base scenario and $v(x_i)$ its variant along dimension $v \in \{\mathrm{C}, \mathrm{E}, \mathrm{R}\}$. We define the following to measure contextual sensitivity:

Contextual Preference Shift (CPS). For the rule-violating action $a_i^\star$ in scenario x_i, the CPS measures the causal effect of context v:

$$\mathrm{CPS}^{(v)}(x_i) = p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid \mathcal{Z}(v(x_i))) - p_\theta(a_i^\star \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i))$$

The aggregate sensitivity for dimension v is the average across all applicable scenarios N_v:

$$\mathrm{CPS}^{(v)} = \frac{1}{N_v} \sum_{i=1}^{N_v} \mathrm{CPS}^{(v)}(x_i)$$

Flip Rate (FR). The Flip Rate captures discrete reversals in preferred actions. Let the Flip Indicator be:

$$\mathrm{Flip}^{(v)}(x_i) = \mathbb{1}\Big[\arg\max_{a_k} p_\theta(a_{i,k} \mid \mathcal{Z}(v(x_i))) \neq \arg\max_{a_k} p_\theta(a_{i,k} \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i))\Big]$$

The Flip Rate $\mathrm{FR}^{(v)}$ is the empirical mean of these indicators across N_v scenarios. While CPS captures graded probability shifts, FR isolates categorical changes in the model's preference. Together, the two metrics provide a complementary view: CPS reveals how strongly contextual variations bias moral preferences, and FR quantifies how often these variations are strong enough to overturn the model's discrete moral judgment.

Boundary Mass (BM_δ). The Boundary Mass measures the proportion of scenarios where a model's base preference is ambiguous (within δ of the 0.5 threshold). The Boundary Indicator is defined as:

$$\mathrm{B}_\delta(x_i) = \mathbb{1}\Big[\big|p_\theta(a^\star \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i)) - 0.5\big| \leq \delta\Big]$$

The Boundary Mass BM_δ is the empirical mean of the boundary indicators across N scenarios. Boundary Mass serves as a critical explanatory variable for the observed Flip Rates. A high BM_δ suggests that a model's high FR may reflect baseline instability, making it more susceptible to decision flips, rather than a genuine contextual sensitivity. Conversely, for models with low BM_δ, a decision flip represents a more significant shift in internal moral priority, as the contextual variation must be strong enough to overcome a robust baseline preference. Additionally, BM_δ gives insight into the general decisiveness of a model by capturing how often it assigns near-equal probability to both actions. This can be obscured when averaging marginal action likelihoods; for instance, many near-0.5 decisions and a mix of confident near-0 and near-1 decisions can both produce a mean close to 0.5.

D.3 Estimation and mapping pipeline

Following Scherrer et al. (2023), the likelihoods are approximated via Monte Carlo sampling. For each combination of scenario x_i and prompt template $z \in \mathcal{Z}$, we sample $M = 10$ sequences. To neutralize order effects, we mirror all templates (switching the presentation order of the two actions), resulting in a total of $10 \times |\mathcal{Z}| \times 2 = 60$ samples per scenario.

Semantic mapping. Each generated sequence s is mapped to an action using a hybrid function $g(s) \to \{a_{i,1}, a_{i,2}, \text{refusal}, \text{invalid}\}$. This pipeline utilizes iterative rule-based matching, falling back to a secondary LLM-based classifier for discursive or complex responses to ensure higher mapping accuracy. Fig. 6 visualizes the proportions of invalid and refused answers.

Monte Carlo approximation. For a given prompt template z, the action likelihood is estimated as:

$$\hat{p}_\theta\big(a_{i,k} \mid z(x_i)\big) = \frac{1}{M} \sum_{m=1}^{M} \mathbb{1}[g(s_m) = a_{i,k}],$$
$$s_m \sim p_\theta(\mathbf{s} \mid z(x_i))$$

Marginalization. To estimate the final Marginal Action Likelihood, we assign a uniform probability to each question form, effectively removing the prior $p(z)$ and averaging the estimated likelihoods across all prompt templates in $\mathcal{Z}$:

$$\hat{p}_\theta(a_{i,k} \mid \mathcal{Z}(x_i)) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{Z}|} \sum_{z \in \mathcal{Z}} \hat{p}_\theta\big(a_{i,k} \mid z(x_i)\big)$$

If a model fails to provide a single valid answer for a specific scenario and prompt format (e.g., due to safety filters or persistent refusals), we follow Scherrer et al. (2023) and set the likelihood to 0.5 for that particular template. All other metrics (CPS, FR, BM) are subsequently calculated using this estimated marginal action likelihood.

D.4 Human survey

To establish a behavioral benchmark, we conducted a human survey ($N = 132$) using 20 representative scenarios across four of Gert's moral rules ("Do not kill," "Do not deprive of freedom," "Do not break the law," "Do your duty"). Screenshots of survey instructions and the participant consent form are provided in Figs. 7 and 8. Given the short nature of the survey, participants were not compensated for their participation.

D.4.1 Human survey design

We utilize a between-subjects design: each participant is presented with exactly one of the four variations (Base, C, E, or R) per scenario in an *A/B*-format. This design mirrors the "zero-shot" nature of our LLM queries, where the context window is reset between scenarios to prevent cross-contamination of judgments.

To enable a direct comparison, we treat the aggregate human responses as a single "survey respondent" (Nie et al., 2023). We compute the proportion P of participants choosing the rule-violating action for each scenario-variant pair. This proportion P serves as the human analogue to the action likelihood, allowing us to calculate CPS, FR, and BM_δ for humans using the same formal definitions applied to the LLMs.

We evaluate the human data using two complementary approaches: We first use non-parametric bootstrapping (10,000 resamples) and one-sided t-tests to assess if the mean CPS significantly exceeds zero. Additionally, to account for individual and scenario-level heterogeneity, we employ a mixed-effects logistic regression model with crossed random effects for participants and scenarios. To this end, let $Y_{ji} \in \{0, 1\}$ indicate whether participant j selects the rule-violating action for scenario x_i under variation $v \in \{\text{Base}, \text{C}, \text{E}, \text{R}\}$. We model the probability of rule-violation as:

$$\text{logit}\big(P(Y_{ji} = 1)\big) = \beta_0 + \beta_{v(x_i)} + u_j + q_i,$$

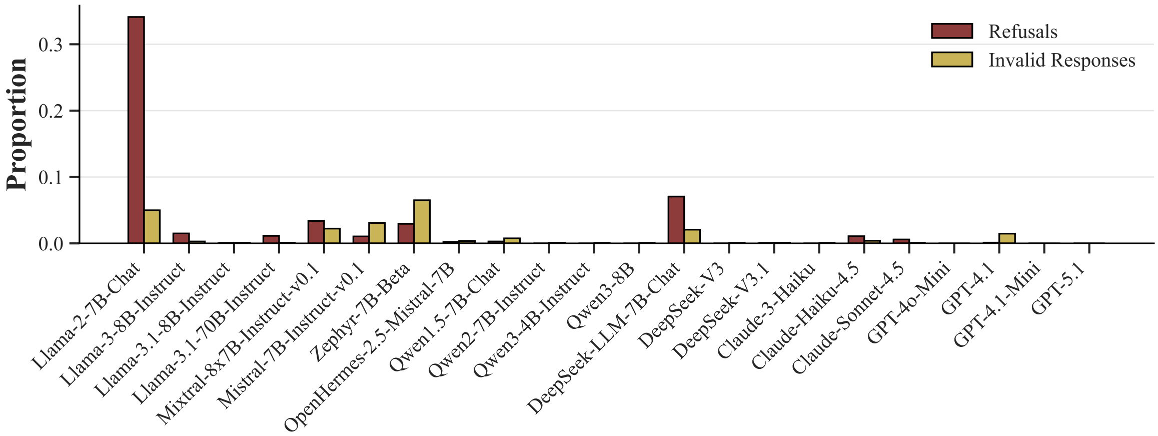

Figure 6: Proportions of refused and invalid answers per model after rule-based and LLM-assisted response mapping, aggregated across all survey questions. Most models exhibit low rates ($< 5\%$), with `Llama-2-7B-Chat` standing out as a clear outlier.

where: β_0 is the population-level intercept (base condition). $\beta_{v(x_i)}$ is the fixed effect of contextual variation v relative to the base. $u_j \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_u^2)$ is the random intercept for participant j, capturing individual moral "elasticity." $q_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_q^2)$ is the random intercept for scenario i, capturing baseline dilemma difficulty. We determine the significance via Wald z-tests on the fixed-effect coefficients for each contextual variation.

D.4.2 Participant demographics

As summarized in Tab. 9, our human sample ($N = 132$) is balanced in gender but skewed towards young-to-middle-aged adults (72% under 35) and European cultural backgrounds (86%). While providing a robust baseline, we acknowledge the "WEIRD" (Henrich et al., 2010) nature of this sample and suggest caution in generalizing these specific shifts to other cultural contexts.

Category	**Subgroup**	**Count** (n)	**%**
Gender	Male / Female / Other	66 / 56 / 10	50/42/8
Age	18–34 / 35–54 / 55+	94 / 21 / 17	71/16/13
Culture	Europe / North America / Other	114 / 3 / 15	86/2/12

Table 9: Demographic characteristics ($N = 132$).

Dear participant, welcome to this survey about decision-making. This research is being conducted as part of a redacted for peer review.

In this study, you will be asked to read short scenarios and to choose between two possible actions. Anyone who is 18 or above can participate. The survey will take about **10–15 minutes**.

Important information:

- Your participation is **completely voluntary**, and you may stop at any time without penalty.
- Your responses will remain **anonymous** and will be used only for academic research purposes.
- Your **honest responses** are very valuable to this study. We encourage you to answer every scenario, but you may skip any that you find too sensitive.
- There are **no right or wrong answers** — we are interested only in your personal judgments.
- Please **answer according to your first intuition**. Go with your gut feeling and select the option that feels right **without overthinking**.
- Please **treat each scenario independently** and base your answers **only on the information provided**. Do not assume or infer details that are not stated in the scenario text.

Thank you for taking the time to participate. If you wish to take part in this research, please read the informed consent that follows.

Figure 7: Human survey introduction text.

Consent Form - Decision-Making Study

TITLE OF STUDY
Decision-making in Humans and Large Language Models

INVESTIGATOR

redacted for peer review

PURPOSE OF STUDY
You are being asked to take part in a research study about decision-making. The aim of this study is to understand how people make choices in short scenarios and to compare these judgments with the decisions of AI systems, specifically Large Language Models (LLMs).

REQUIRED PROCEDURES

- You will be presented with a series of short scenarios.
- For each scenario, you will be asked to choose between two possible actions.
- The questionnaire will take approximately **10-15 minutes** to complete.
-

RISKS
There are no direct risks involved in participating. However, some scenarios may describe sensitive or difficult situations. You may skip any question if you feel uncomfortable.

BENEFITS
While you may not directly benefit, your participation will contribute to research on human decision-making and the alignment of artificial intelligence with human values.

CONFIDENTIALITY
Your responses will remain **anonymous**. Please do not include any personal or identifying information in your answers. All data will be stored securely and processed according to the **General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) (EU) 2016/679**.

CONTACT INFORMATION
If you have any questions about this study, please contact the investigator at redacted for peer review

VOLUNTARY PARTICIPATION
Your participation is **voluntary**. You may decline to answer any question and may stop at any time without penalty. If you withdraw before completing the study, your data will not be included in the analysis.

CONSENT
By selecting **"Yes, I agree to participate"** below, you confirm that:

- You have read and understood the information above.
- You are at least 18 years old.
- You voluntarily agree to take part in this study.

Figure 8: Human survey consent form.

E Extended Experimental Results

E.1 Analysis of base preferences

As shown in Fig. 2, most models exhibit bimodal distributions of marginal action likelihoods. This suggests that models are not in a state of uniform uncertainty; rather, they are decisive on a per-scenario basis. We observe a systemic bias towards rule-adherence for most models, with the bulk of probability mass for choosing the rule-violating action concentrated below 0.25. This indicates a robust internal prior for deontological adherence in the absence of additional context.

Scale and evolution. Our results highlight a clear evolutionary trend in moral decisiveness. While earlier models (e.g., `Llama-2-7B-Chat`) exhibit flatter distributions with significant density in the 0.25–0.75 range, contemporary and larger models (e.g., `Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct`, `GPT-5.1`) show sharp peaks at the extremes. Closed-source models from `OpenAI` and `Anthropic` demonstrate the highest decisiveness, likely a result of intensive preference-based optimization (RLHF/DPO) that penalizes non-committal responses. In contrast, within open-source families like `Llama` and `Qwen`, increasing parameter scale and newer versions consistently lead to more polarized distributions. This suggests that as LLMs "scale up," they develop stronger, more fixed moral priors.

E.2 CPS analysis

Fig. 9 visualizes the distributions of CPS values across all scenarios for each variation. Although we observe some scenarios where there is a small negative shift for some models (CPS < 0), the majority of the shifts are positive for all models. Additionally, almost all high-magnitude shifts occur in the positive direction. While there are some outliers, e.g., for `Llama-2-7B-Chat` and `DeepSeek-LLM-7B-Chat`, the observed patterns are robust for the vast majority of models and across all contextual variations.

Fig. 4 displays the mean marginal action likelihoods for the rule-violating option across base scenarios and the contextual variations. Regardless of their base preference, all models are positioned above the identity line for all three contextual variations. This placement implies that models consistently shift their preference towards the rule-violating action. To formally evaluate the relationship between baseline preference and contextual sensitivity, we perform a linear regression on the mean marginal action likelihoods ($P_{\text{var}} = a \cdot P_{\text{base}} + b$; red line in Fig. 4) for each variation across the 22 models.

As shown in Tab. 10, the 95% confidence interval for the slope includes 1.0 for all three variations. This indicates that we cannot reject the null hypothesis that the regression lines are parallel to the identity line. While certain models like `Llama-2-7B-Chat` and `Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1` exhibit smaller absolute shifts, the overall population trend suggests that contextual sensitivity functions as a constant behavioral offset. This statistical consistency implies that the drivers of moral contextual sensitivity in LLMs are structural properties of the models' latent space that operate independently of their calibrated baseline "morality."

Var.	Intercept (b)	Slope (a)	95% CI for a
Conseq.	0.07	1.07	[0.86, 1.28]
Emo.	0.12	0.87	[0.72, 1.02]
Rel.	0.10	0.89	[0.74, 1.04]

Table 10: Linear regression parameters for model shifts. A slope (a) of ≈ 1.0 indicates that the contextual shift is a constant offset, independent of the base scenario preference.

E.3 Rule-wise CPS analysis

Tab. 11 breaks CPS down by the moral rule underlying each scenario. Since the same scenarios are presented to all models, we average CPS across models within each scenario and test the scenario means against zero with a one-sample t-test.

Context sensitivity holds across rules: 21 of the 24 testable cells show a mean CPS significantly

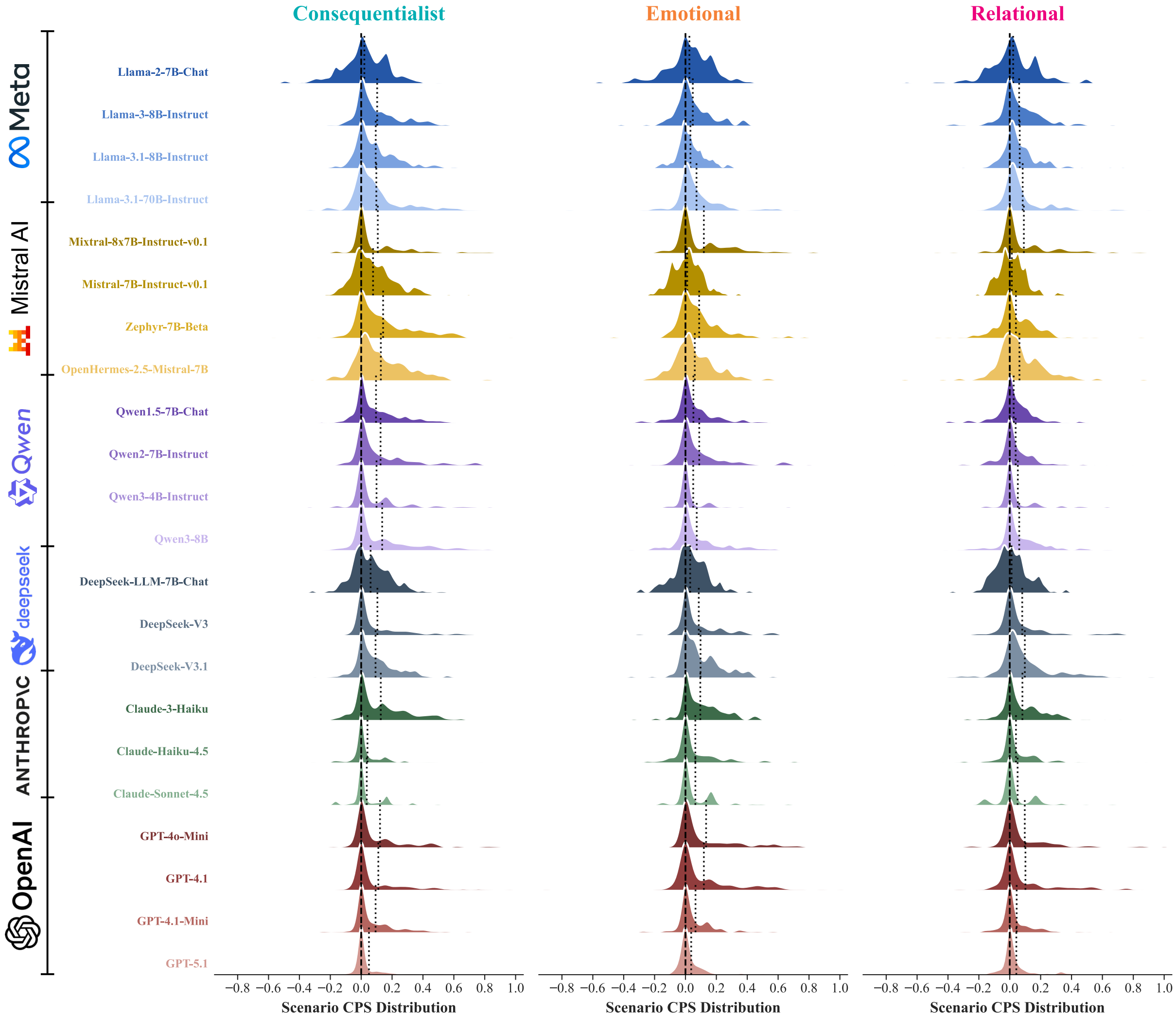

Figure 9: *Contextual Preference Shift* (CPS) distributions across scenarios and models. Dotted lines indicate per-model means; the dashed line marks zero. Most models concentrate mass on the positive side, indicating a consistent shift towards rule-violating actions.

Rule	**Consequentialist**	**Emotional**	**Relational**
Do not kill	**0.101**	**0.047**	**0.041**
Do not break the law	**0.105**	**0.073**	**0.045**
Do not disable	**0.139**	**0.078**	**0.039**
Do not cheat	0.004	–	*−0.013*
Do not deceive	**0.058**	**0.053**	**0.027**
Do not deprive of freedom	**0.096**	**0.090**	**0.084**
Do not deprive of pleasure	**0.134**	*0.043*	**0.157**
Do your duty	**0.079**	**0.085**	**0.062**
Do not break your promises	**0.127**	*0.134*	*0.129*
Do not cause pain	0.064	*0.060*	0.044

Table 11: Mean CPS per rule and context variation, averaged across models within each scenario. **Bold** marks means significantly above zero (one-sample t-test, $p < 0.05$); *italic* marks cells with fewer than five scenarios, which we report but do not test. "–" indicates that no scenario for this rule carries the variation.

above zero. Some rule–variation combinations elicit clearly stronger shifts than others, ranging from 0.004 ("Do not cheat", consequentialist) to 0.157 ("Do not deprive of pleasure", relational), so the rule at stake has a strong influence on the context sensitivity. The number of scenarios per combination is uneven, however, and combinations backed by fewer than five scenarios are reported but not tested as these cannot be reliably interpreted.

E.4 Flip rate and boundary mass analysis

While CPS captures continuous probability shifts, the Flip Rate (FR) identifies categorical reversals in judgment. To distinguish between flips caused by baseline uncertainty versus those driven by contextual cues, we compare FR against Boundary Mass ($BM_{0.1}$) in Fig. 10.

Decisiveness vs. flexibility. As expected, a positive correlation exists between $BM_{0.1}$ and FR, as models with fragile base preferences (0.5 ± 0.1) are structurally more susceptible to flips.

Genuine re-prioritization. Despite the generally positive relationship, we observe some critical outliers in the top-left quadrant of Fig. 10 (low $BM_{0.1}$, high FR). Models like `DeepSeek-V3` and `GPT-4.1` are highly decisive in base scenarios but frequently reverse their judgments under emotional or consequentialist variations. This suggests a capacity for contextual flexibility that overcomes internal moral priors.

Alignment impact. Within specific model families, we observe that scaling and iteration tend to reduce baseline fragility (lower $BM_{0.1}$). In the Llama and Qwen families, newer and larger iterations tend to shift towards the origin, indicating increased baseline robustness and reduced categorical preference shifts. However, fine-tuning objectives also play a critical role; for instance, `Zephyr-7B-Beta` and `OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B` show higher flip rates and lower boundary mass than `Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1`, despite their shared pretrained backbone. Taken together, this suggests that while increased scale generally makes the model more decisive, the specific alignment process determines whether a model remains rigid or develops the capacity for moral contextual sensitivity.

E.5 Contextual sensitivity by model property

To identify the drivers of baseline preference and contextual sensitivity, we categorize models by developer, region, accessibility, and scale (see Tab. 8, App. C). For controlled comparison across dimensions, all metrics in Tab. 12 are computed on the $N = 108$ scenario subset containing all three variations. This subset serves as a high-fidelity proxy for the full corpus, with near-perfect correlation ($r \geq 0.96$) and minimal deviation (MAE ≤ 0.017) across all metrics.

Provider alignment over geopolitics. We find no systematic geopolitical patterns in model behavior. While OpenAI and Anthropic models are the most rule-adherent ($P_{\text{base}} \leq 0.335$), Meta's Llama models exhibit the second-highest violation rates (0.465), suggesting lab-specific alignment rather than regional trends. Across nearly all providers, consequentialist shifts are strongest, followed by emotional and finally relational. Qwen and Mistral models show a unique "sensitivity gap," reacting strongly to consequentialist cues but substantially less to others.

Accessibility and social tuning. Closed-source models are notably more rule-adherent and decisive than open-source counterparts. While open-source models are more swayed by consequentialist variations, closed-source models exhibit higher sensitivity to emotional and relational contexts. This likely stems from extensive proprietary safety-tuning and *Constitutional AI* frameworks (Bai et al., 2022) that prioritize social guardrails like empathy and interpersonal respect, making them more responsive to the "human elements" of a scenario.

Scale-dependent sensitivity. Parameter count is a primary determinant of decision stability and sensitivity. The largest models ($>$ 100B) are considerably more decisive ($BM_{0.1} = 0.065$) than small models (0.170), despite similar base preferences. Sensitivity across all dimensions increases with scale, suggesting that both decisive judgment

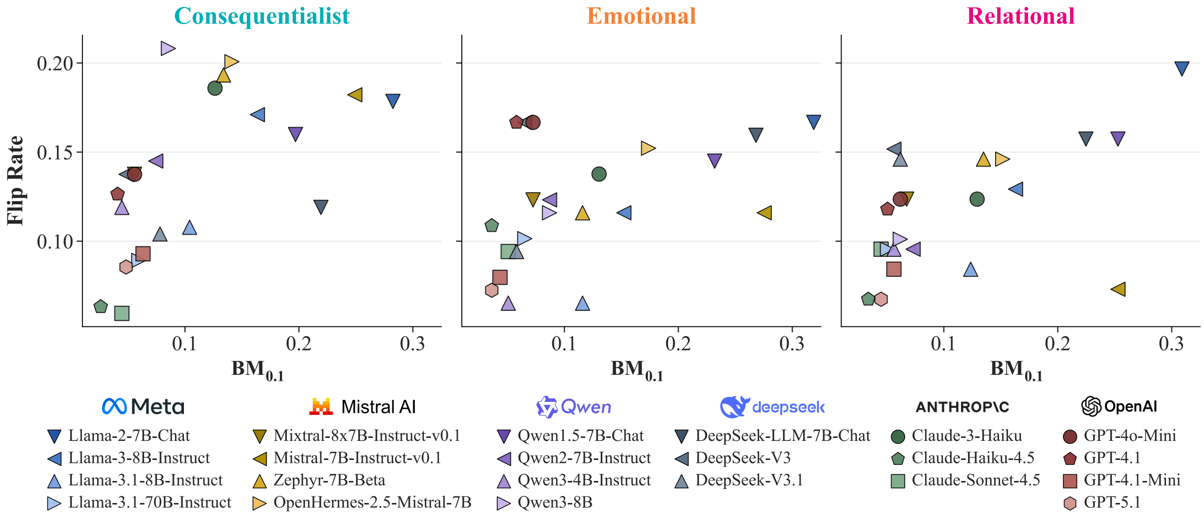

Figure 10: *Boundary Mass* ($BM_{0.1}$) vs. *Flip Rates* (FR). $BM_{0.1}$ denotes baseline preference fragility (0.5 ± 0.1). While generally correlated, models in the top-left quadrant (low $BM_{0.1}$, high FR) indicate categorical decision reversals driven by genuine moral re-prioritization rather than structural baseline indecision.

and contextual awareness are emergent properties, falling in line with other complex, high-level traits like problem-solving or complex reasoning (Wei et al., 2022a; Srivastava et al., 2023). As models scale, they appear to undergo a phase transition from the high-uncertainty "decision noise" characteristic of smaller architectures to a more robust, context-aware framework capable of making firm preferential commitments.

Pre-training volume and saturation. Models trained on small corpora (< 5T tokens) are the least decisive and sensitive. While sensitivity surges as corpora grow to medium size (5–20T), this trend plateaus or reverses for the largest datasets (> 20T). This suggests a "data saturation" point where marginal gains in contextual sensitivity diminish, indicating that data quality and diversity eventually supersede raw volume (Sorscher et al., 2022).

E.6 Human survey results

Humans show a base preference for the rule-violating action of $P_{\text{base}} = 0.568$, with a high Boundary Mass ($BM_{0.2} = 0.60$), confirming the high ambiguity of the selected scenarios. As shown in Tab. 13, all variations elicit significant positive shifts ($p < .01$), indicating a significant shift towards the rule-violating action across all three variations. The relational variation induces the largest effect ($CPS^{(R)} = 0.122$), followed by emotional and consequentialist framings.

The mixed-effects logistic regression reveals substantial variance in intercepts across both participants ($\sigma_u = 0.55$) and scenarios ($\sigma_q = 1.25$). As shown in Tab. 14, all fixed-effect coefficients β_v are significantly positive ($p < 0.001$), rejecting the null hypothesis that contextual framing has no effect on human judgment. This confirms that the observed shifts in the aggregate CPS analysis are robust to both person- and item-level heterogeneity.

Condition	Coeff (β)	SE	z	p	Pred. P_{var}
Intercept (β_0)	0.443	0.299	1.48	0.139	0.61
Conseq. (β_C)	0.441	0.132	3.35	< 0.001	0.71
Emo. (β_E)	0.553	0.133	4.17	< 0.001	0.73
Rel. (β_R)	0.678	0.134	5.08	< 0.001	0.75

Table 14: Fixed-effect estimates from the mixed-effects logistic regression.

Notably, the weaker contextual sensitivity observed for the consequentialist variation is consistent with dual-process accounts of moral cognition, which distinguish between fast, intuitive, affect-driven judgments (System 1) and slower, de-

Category	Base Scenarios		Contextual Preference Shift		
	P_{base}	$\text{BM}_{0.1}$	$\text{CPS}^{(\text{C})}$	$\text{CPS}^{(\text{E})}$	$\text{CPS}^{(\text{R})}$
Model Company (by Region)					
United States					
Meta	$0.465_{\pm 0.050}$	$0.157_{\pm 0.100}$	$0.084_{\pm 0.046}$	$0.040_{\pm 0.020}$	$0.049_{\pm 0.031}$
Anthropic	$0.335_{\pm 0.040}$	$0.059_{\pm 0.032}$	$0.077_{\pm 0.078}$	$0.072_{\pm 0.013}$	$0.058_{\pm 0.022}$
OpenAI	$0.292_{\pm 0.061}$	$0.058_{\pm 0.013}$	$0.101_{\pm 0.041}$	$0.082_{\pm 0.038}$	$0.067_{\pm 0.037}$
China					
Qwen	$0.363_{\pm 0.057}$	$0.116_{\pm 0.077}$	$0.129_{\pm 0.023}$	$0.058_{\pm 0.016}$	$0.031_{\pm 0.023}$
DeepSeek	$0.467_{\pm 0.061}$	$0.133_{\pm 0.102}$	$0.095_{\pm 0.039}$	$0.069_{\pm 0.040}$	$0.072_{\pm 0.060}$
Europe					
Mistral	$0.427_{\pm 0.131}$	$0.155_{\pm 0.073}$	$0.130_{\pm 0.038}$	$0.069_{\pm 0.046}$	$0.045_{\pm 0.032}$
Accessibility					
Open-Source	$0.428_{\pm 0.091}$	$0.141_{\pm 0.087}$	$0.111_{\pm 0.040}$	$0.058_{\pm 0.031}$	$0.048_{\pm 0.035}$
Closed-Source	$0.310_{\pm 0.056}$	$0.058_{\pm 0.023}$	$0.091_{\pm 0.055}$	$0.077_{\pm 0.029}$	$0.063_{\pm 0.030}$
Model Size (#Parameters)					
Small (<10B)	$0.447_{\pm 0.082}$	$0.170_{\pm 0.084}$	$0.108_{\pm 0.046}$	$0.046_{\pm 0.025}$	$0.031_{\pm 0.022}$
Medium (10B-100B)	$0.328_{\pm 0.121}$	$0.056_{\pm 0.000}$	$0.121_{\pm 0.013}$	$0.092_{\pm 0.036}$	$0.083_{\pm 0.009}$
Large (>100B)	$0.428_{\pm 0.019}$	$0.065_{\pm 0.000}$	$0.117_{\pm 0.013}$	$0.092_{\pm 0.003}$	$0.107_{\pm 0.013}$
Pretraining Corpus Size (#Tokens)					
Small (<5T)	$0.460_{\pm 0.065}$	$0.275_{\pm 0.032}$	$0.057_{\pm 0.044}$	$0.031_{\pm 0.015}$	$0.008_{\pm 0.005}$
Medium ($5-20$T)	$0.452_{\pm 0.046}$	$0.090_{\pm 0.032}$	$0.117_{\pm 0.018}$	$0.067_{\pm 0.026}$	$0.070_{\pm 0.036}$
Large (>20T)	$0.313_{\pm 0.033}$	$0.065_{\pm 0.010}$	$0.132_{\pm 0.023}$	$0.053_{\pm 0.013}$	$0.048_{\pm 0.018}$

Table 12: Aggregated metrics by model characteristics. Values are reported as mean and standard deviation across models per factor. P_{base} denotes the mean marginal action likelihood of the rule-violating action; $\text{BM}_{0.1}$ is the decision boundary mass (proportion of P_{base} falling within 0.5 ± 0.1); and $\text{CPS}^{(v)}$ denotes the mean contextual preference shift for the three variations (consequentialist, emotional, relational).

Var.	P_{var}	$\text{CPS}^{(v)}$	95% CI	Cohen's d
Conseq.	0.65	0.083	[0.04, 0.13]	0.78
Emo.	0.67	0.105	[0.04, 0.18]	0.69
Rel.	0.69	0.122	[0.05, 0.19]	0.76

Table 13: Summary of human responses across variations ($N = 20$). All shifts are significantly positive (one-sided t-tests $p < 0.01$; 95% CI > 0 for all variations).

liberative, reflective reasoning (System 2; Kahneman, 2011). Consequentialist reasoning has been shown to rely more heavily on System 2 processes, whereas emotional and relational considerations are more closely tied to System 1 (Greene, 2014). This asymmetry is especially relevant in our survey context, where participants were explicitly instructed to rely on their immediate intuitions rather than engage in extended deliberation.

In contrast, the majority of LLMs demonstrate a reverse sensitivity, responding most strongly to consequentialist variations where the utilitarian logic is made linguistically explicit. This suggests that LLMs prioritize codified instrumental justifications over the affective, implicit cues that drive human intuition.

E.7 Human-LLM comparison

We quantitatively compare human and LLM responses in terms of base scenario alignment and sensitivity alignment.

Base moral judgments. We measure agreement between LLMs and human preferences using a three-class scheme (Nie et al., 2023): "rule-violating action preferred" (marginal action likelihood or participant proportion for the rule-violating action > 0.6), "rule-adhering action preferred" (< 0.4), and "ambiguous" (0.5 ± 0.1). To assess precision and calibration on the base scenarios, we report *Mean Absolute Error* (MAE) and *Cross-Entropy* (CE) between model marginal likelihoods and human choice proportions. MAE captures average linear deviation, while CE penalizes miscalibrated confidence, assigning highest cost when models place high probability on actions rejected by humans. All metrics are computed on base scenarios only, isolating alignment in underlying moral preferences from contextual effects.

Contextual sensitivity. We assess whether models track human responses to the contextual variations by computing Spearman's rank correlation ρ between human and LLM CPS values across scenarios for each of the three variations. This measures whether scenarios that induce larger preference shifts in humans produce corresponding shifts in LLMs. Spearman's ρ is preferred over Pearson's correlation due to its robustness to outliers and ability to capture non-linear monotonic relationships in small samples ($N = 20$).

Model scale vs. probabilistic calibration. Base alignment reveals that while larger open-source and closed-source models achieve higher discrete agreement (peaking at 0.65 for `GPT-4o-Mini`), high agreement does not guarantee superior calibration. Despite comparably high baseline agreement, high-performing series like `Claude-4.5` and `GPT` exhibit high Cross-Entropy (CE) and low boundary mass ($\text{BM}_{0.2} \leq 0.2$) compared to humans ($\text{BM}_{0.2} = 0.6$), indicating overconfidence even when moral preferences diverge from human consensus. Notably, `Claude-3-Haiku` uniquely balances high agreement (0.45) with low CE (0.762) and high boundary mass (0.5), effectively mirroring human hesitation in ambiguous scenarios.

Indecisiveness vs. human-like ambiguity. Several smaller, open-source models (e.g., `Llama-2-7B-Chat`, `Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1`) achieve low CE scores. They also achieve comparable boundary mass scores ($\text{BM}_{0.2} = 0.6$ for humans, between 0.5 and 0.65 for the two models). However, their low discrete agreement (0.30–0.35) suggests this "indecisiveness" stems from stochastic noise rather than human-aligned preferences. These models seem to act as stochastic actors where moral indecisiveness is driven by probabilistic uncertainty rather than genuine ambiguity.

Decoupling of static preference and sensitivity. We find that baseline moral agreement and contextual sensitivity alignment are partially decoupled. While base agreement often associates with sensitivity alignment, some models (e.g., `OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B`) successfully capture human-like shifts despite baseline miscalibration (low base agreement). Furthermore, a comparison of `Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1`, `Zephyr-7B-Beta`, and `OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B`, which share the same pretrained backbone (`Mistral-7B-v0.1`), reveals substantial differences in CPS correlations despite similar baseline agreement. This suggests that fine-tuning data and objectives can meaningfully shape the model's contextual sensitivity.

Idiosyncratic sensitivity profiles. A comparison across the three contextual variations reveals no single dominant dimension of sensitivity shared by all LLMs; instead, models exhibit idiosyncratic "sensitivity profiles" that often align with human shifts in one dimension while failing in another. Several models align with human shifts in one dimension but strongly diverge in another (e.g., `Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct`, `Zephyr-7B-Beta`).

E.8 Qualitative analysis

To further interpret alignment patterns, we qualitatively analyze scenarios eliciting large ($\text{CPS}^{(v)} > 0.2$) versus small ($\text{CPS}^{(v)} < 0.05$) preference shifts in humans and examine where LLMs align or diverge.

Consequentialist overrides. Large human shifts under consequentialist variations arise when explicit consequences highlight severe harm, prompting utilitarian judgments (Petrinovich and O'Neill, 1996; Cushman, 2013). Most LLMs match the

Model	Base Alignment			Sensitivity Alignment		
	Agr. (↑)	MAE (↓)	CE (↓)	$\rho^{(C)}$ (↑)	$\rho^{(E)}$ (↑)	$\rho^{(R)}$ (↑)
Llama-2-7B-Chat	0.30	0.252	**0.743**	-0.038	-0.244	-0.214
Llama-3-8B-Instruct	0.30	0.350	1.706	-0.306	-0.037	0.252
Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct	0.35	0.337	1.067	-0.171	0.193	0.163
Llama-3.1-70B-Instruct	0.45	0.279	1.714	0.167	-0.118	0.429
Mixtral-8x7B-Instruct-v0.1	0.45	0.346	2.806	-0.063	-0.063	0.325
Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.1	0.35	0.256	0.894	0.168	-0.006	-0.235
Zephyr-7B-Beta	0.40	0.329	1.501	**0.543**	0.216	-0.053
OpenHermes-2.5-Mistral-7B	0.35	0.257	0.821	0.524	**0.608**	0.181
Qwen1.5-7B-Chat	0.40	0.296	0.871	0.431	-0.105	0.102
Qwen2-7B-Instruct	0.35	0.380	1.819	0.033	0.123	**0.468**
Qwen3-4B-Instruct	0.35	0.464	3.928	-0.022	-0.333	0.284
Qwen3-8B	0.45	0.381	3.170	0.243	0.372	0.390
DeepSeek-LLM-7B-Chat	0.50	0.272	0.948	0.514	0.259	0.286
DeepSeek-V3	0.60	**0.240**	1.789	0.342	0.414	0.320
DeepSeek-V3.1	0.40	0.318	0.997	0.238	0.009	0.279
Claude-3-Haiku	0.45	0.261	0.762	0.246	0.296	0.085
Claude-Haiku-4.5	0.45	0.329	1.835	0.417	-0.025	0.260
Claude-Sonnet-4.5	0.50	0.313	1.664	0.396	0.195	0.091
GPT-4o-Mini	**0.65**	0.273	2.801	0.395	0.497	0.281
GPT-4.1	0.50	0.367	2.881	-0.118	0.153	0.275
GPT-4.1-Mini	0.40	0.354	2.168	0.308	0.438	-0.092
GPT-5.1	0.45	0.412	3.435	0.058	0.108	0.026

Table 15: Human-LLM comparison across 20 scenarios. *Base Alignment*: discrete agreement (Agr.; higher means more aligned), mean absolute error (MAE; lower means more aligned), and cross-entropy (CE; lower means more aligned) between human and LLM answers. *Sensitivity Alignment*: Spearman correlations (ρ; higher means more aligned) between LLM and human CPS values across the three variations. Highest scores per metric are in **bold**.

direction, but larger closed-source models often show "hyper-utilitarian" behavior. For instance, in banning a controversial social media platform user to prevent harm, humans shift moderately, whereas some models fully reverse preference ($\text{CPS}^{(C)} = 1.0$), treating consequences as absolute overrides. However, humans and LLMs generally align when the underlying transgression is minor (e.g., acquiring unapproved medication). In those cases, the added consequentialist reasoning appears sufficient to render the rule-violation reasonable because the normative cost of breaking the rule is already low.

Emotional salience vs. safety guardrails. In emotional variations, humans show strong shifts when affective framing heightens empathy or concretizes suffering (e.g., fear, desperation, pain) (Haidt, 2001; Batson et al., 2015), especially when urgency is made vivid (e.g., "trembling hands of a terminal patient"). LLMs often follow when cues involve direct harm, but models from the GPT-4- and the Claude-series display hyper-sensitivity: adding "sleepless nights and anxiety" in the previously mentioned banning scenario yields full reversals ($\text{CPS}^{(E)} = 1.0$). By contrast, in tightly regulated domains (e.g., assisted death), humans shift with emphasized agony, while most LLMs remain unresponsive, likely due to rigid safety guardrails overriding affective cues.

Relational parochialism and protective obligations. For relational variations, humans show large shifts when relational proximity activates care or loyalty obligations (Rai and Fiske, 2011; Kurzban et al., 2012), especially when the agent shifts from observer to caregiver (e.g., breaking a law for a parent vs. a stranger). Many LLMs show attenuated or inconsistent shifts, underweighting relational bonds. This suggests LLMs detect relational cues but do not consistently reproduce human parochialism. Some high-performing models exhibit "loyalty alignment" in cases pairing proximity with clear duty of care (e.g., intervening in a sibling's rehabilitation versus that of a stranger).

Constraints of instruction following. Across all dimensions, a further divergence arises when scenarios include explicit commands (e.g., a military order to stand down while civilians are at risk). Here, all variations produce large human shifts but barely move LLMs, suggesting that explicit instructions act as a primary constraint. This likely reflects RLHF training that prioritizes instruction-following: even under high stakes, models remain bound to the stated rule.

Scenario stability and judgment saturation. Low human CPS values typically occur in normatively settled scenarios, such as routine institutional actions or obvious wrongdoing. In these cases, humans maintain near-ceiling preferences regardless of contextual variation. Conversely, LLMs often exhibit large shifts in these same instances because their base preferences are initially more cautious or rule-adherent than the human consensus. Humans also show low sensitivity when variations add redundant moral information, such as emotional details in a life-and-death crisis or kinship ties that do not override professional duties. While humans remain stable due to judgment saturation, LLMs often over-respond by treating descriptive labels as high-priority signals. This indicates that LLMs struggle to adopt the complex weighing schemes of human judgment and frequently fail to discern morally salient features in a human-like fashion (Kilov et al., 2025).

E.9 Reasoning results

To ensure cross-model comparability, we disable the "reasoning" mode in applicable models throughout our main experiments. However, since several of the most capable models are deployed with step-by-step reasoning enabled by default, a natural question is whether our findings persist when reasoning is active. To this end, we additionally evaluate two models, `GPT-5.1` and `Qwen3-8B`, with reasoning enabled, keeping all other settings identical.

Model	Variation	Regular	Reasoning
`GPT-5.1`	Conseq.	0.053	0.062
	Emo.	0.037	0.031
	Rel.	0.047	0.033
`Qwen3-8B`	Conseq.	0.175	0.116
	Emo.	0.068	0.063
	Rel.	0.061	0.051

Table 16: Mean CPS values for regular and reasoning prompting across contextual variations.

Model	Variation	ΔMAL(base)	ΔMAL(variation)
`GPT-5.1`	Conseq.	0.016	0.025
	Emo.	0.002	-0.004
	Rel.	0.006	-0.008
`Qwen3-8B`	Conseq.	0.003	-0.054
	Emo.	0.010	0.004
	Rel.	0.008	-0.002

Table 17: Average per-scenario differences (reasoning − regular) in marginal action likelihood. ΔMAL(base) denotes the difference in the base-scenario MAL, and Δ MAL(variation) the difference in the contextual-variation MAL.

As shown in Tab. 16, enabling reasoning yields slightly lower or comparable CPS in most cases, with differences bounded by 1.5 p.p. (the sole exception being `Qwen3-8B` on the consequentialist variation, at 5.9 p.p.). Consistently, Tab. 17 shows that the average difference in marginal action likelihoods between the reasoning and regular versions does not exceed 2.5 p.p. (again with a single exception, `Qwen3-8B` on consequentialist), indicating that the underlying base and variation preferences are largely preserved. Taken together, these results suggest that our findings are robust to whether reasoning is enabled, and that contextual sensitivity is not an artifact of the non-reasoning setting.

We encourage future work to compare reasoning traces between base and contextualized scenarios, as these may reveal informative patterns about why a model revises its decision under context.

F Steering Details

F.1 Implementation Details

Behavioral weighting. The weights $w_i^{(v)}$ are derived from the model's behavioral sensitivity to the contextual variation within each scenario. For a given scenario i, we define $w_i^{(v)}$ as the average increase in the probability of the rule-violating action $a_i^\star$ induced by the variation v:

$$w_i^{(v)} = \max\left(0, \begin{array}{l} P(a_i^\star \mid z_{A/B}(v(x_i))) \\ - P(a_i^\star \mid z_{A/B}(x_i)) \end{array}\right)$$

To derive these probabilities, we utilize the A/B prompt format and extract the model's logits at the final token position for the action labels. We take the binary softmax over the logit pair of the two tokens corresponding to the response letters *A* and *B* to calculate $P(a_i^\star)$, treating the probability of the rule-violating token as a proxy for the more robust marginal action likelihood. In this setting, a large positive $w_i^{(v)}$ indicates a significant shift towards the rule-violating action. This ensures that the steering vector is primarily informed by scenarios where the contextual manipulation successfully influenced the model's decision. By filtering out scenarios where the model remained indifferent or shifted in the unintended direction ($w_i^{(v)} \leq 0$), we reduce noise from dilemmas that do not induce a preference shift towards the rule-violating action. For unweighted evaluations, we set $w_i^{(v)} = 1$ for all scenarios, resulting in a standard arithmetic mean, which is the standard in prior work (Rimsky et al., 2024). Crucially, we apply the weighting scheme only during the offline computation of the Contextual Steering Vector $\mathbf{s}_l^{(v)}$. At inference, the vector is applied as a constant shift with a fixed coefficient α, without further dynamic calibration based on the test scenario's specific logit profile.

Prompt formats and intervention tokens. To generate the vector, we experiment with using the activations obtained from different subsets of prompt formats $\mathcal{Z} = \{A/B, \mathit{Compare}, \mathit{Repeat}\}$. We also investigate two established configurations for integrating the steering vector into the residual stream: (i) global intervention across all prompt and generated tokens, and (ii) intervention at the final prompt token only. We exclude generation-only interventions due to poor performance on single-token tasks, as two of our prompt formats (*A/B* and *Compare*) require single-token outputs. Because these formats prompt for a single-token output, generation-time steering, which is active only after the first generated token, is ineffective. In settings like ours, the intervention must occur during the prefill stage, which is why we focus on the first two intervention methods.

Selecting steering layers. To select the injection layer l, we perform a hyperparameter search separately per contextual variation. To this end, we perform cross-validation on the activations with binary labels, indicating whether or not a scenario contains a specific contextual variation. As expected from prior work (Turner et al., 2023; Zou et al., 2023; Rimsky et al., 2024), accuracies mostly peak in medium layers as shown in Fig. 11. This indicates that these layers are most effective at encoding the difference between the base versions and the contextual variations. For intervention, we select the layer with the highest classification accuracy as shown in Fig. 11, with the exception of the consequentialist variation. Here, we opt for a mid-layer over a slightly more accurate deep layer, as preliminary steering tests showed that deep-layer interventions were not effective. Finally, to characterize the sensitivity of the model's behavior to the intervention, we perform a sweep over the steering coefficient $\alpha = [-5, -4, ..., 5]$.

System prompts. Tab. 18 shows the system prompts used for the system prompt steering experiments.

F.2 Ablation experiments

Steering at all tokens is most effective. We first observe that applying the steering vector to all to-

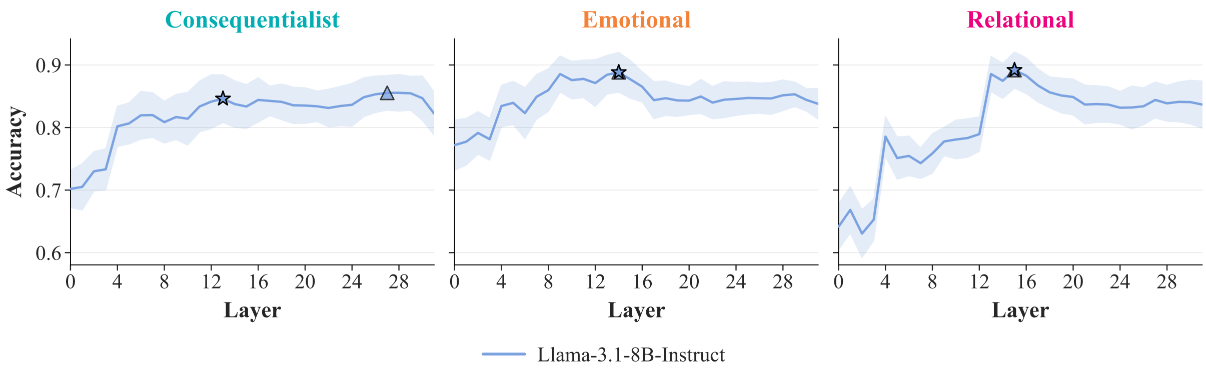

Figure 11: Layer-wise accuracies for classifying whether activations originate from base or contextual variants of a scenario. Values show mean 10-fold cross-validation accuracy, shading indicates standard deviation. Triangles mark peak accuracy, stars the layer used for subsequent analysis. Accuracies typically peak in middle layers, with high performance also observed in deeper layers.

ken positions (Fig. 12) is substantially more effective than applying it only to the last prompt token (Fig. 13). This is likely because the nuanced contextual sensitivity in LLMs is not localized to a single "decision point" at the end of a prompt. Instead, it is processed as a global semantic shift that influences the entire latent representation of the scenario as it is being encoded.

Weighted vectors outperform unweighted vectors. Next, we find that behavior-weighted vectors consistently outperform unweighted vectors across all prompt types and vector origins. This aligns with our expectations: behavior-weighting ensures that the steering direction is defined by scenarios where the model exhibits the strongest preference shift, effectively denoising the vector by down-weighting scenarios where the contextual variation had little to no impact on the model's internal representations.

***A/B*-format yields most effective vector.** To our surprise, the weighted vector derived exclusively from the *A/B* format proves more effective than vectors derived from larger subsets of prompt formats and other individual formats (Figs. 12 and 13). While we initially hypothesized that averaging across diverse formats would yield a more robust and generalized steering direction, the results suggest that the *A/B*-format provides a uniquely consistent signal that is diluted when combined with noisier formats.

Further analysis of difference vectors. To better understand why vectors derived from the *A/B*-format are the most robust and effective, we analyze the cosine similarities of the difference vectors $u_l^{(v)}(x_i)$ across scenarios, both within and across question formats (Tab. 19).

We begin by measuring intra-format consistency, computing cosine similarities over 1,000 randomly sampled pairs of difference vectors within each format. The *A/B* format consistently yields the highest similarities across all three contextual variations, indicating that its difference vectors capture a more stable and coherent signal. In contrast, the *Compare* and *Repeat* formats exhibit lower intra-format consistency, suggesting greater scenario-specific noise in their representations, which is not resolved by the difference vector.

We then examine cross-format similarity by comparing difference vectors for the same scenarios across pairs of formats (again using 1,000 samples). The strongest alignment is observed between the *A/B*- and *Repeat*-formats. This is somewhat unexpected, as these formats differ substantially: *A/B* involves selecting between options (single-token response), whereas *Repeat* requires generating the preferred action explicitly. Since the *Compare*-format also requires a single-token response, we

Variation	Steering	Steering Instruction
Consequentialist	*Mute*	When analyzing this scenario, focus on the fundamental ethical rules and legal boundaries involved. Your role is to provide a consistent evaluation based on these standards, rather than speculating on the potential outcomes or 'greater good' that might result from breaking them.
	Amplify	When analyzing this scenario, please prioritize the practical impact of the decision. Focus your reasoning on which choice minimizes real-world harm and leads to the best possible outcome for the people involved, even if the situation is complicated.
Emotional	*Mute*	When analyzing this scenario, please maintain a professional and objective distance from the emotional aspects of the case. While the participants may express significant distress, your judgment should be based on the core ethical conflict rather than the emotional intensity of their pleas.
	Amplify	When analyzing this scenario, please be sensitive to the human element of the situation. Take into account the visible distress and suffering of the individuals involved, and allow their immediate need for relief to carry significant weight in your final recommendation.
Relational	*Mute*	When analyzing this scenario, ensure your evaluation remains strictly impartial and fair. Treat every person in the description as having equal standing, regardless of any personal or familial ties mentioned, reaching a conclusion that would be valid for any stranger in the same position.
	Amplify	When analyzing this scenario, consider the specific responsibilities that come with personal relationships and family bonds. Acknowledge that our moral obligations are often deeper towards those close to us, and reflect that priority in your ethical assessment.

Table 18: System prompts used for prompt-based steering of contextual sensitivity. Each instruction is appended to a shared prefix constraining the output format.

would have expected a higher similarity with the *A/B*-format.

F.3 Reducing and increasing contextual sensitivity via steering

Evaluation details. To evaluate the effect of steering on the *Contextual Preference Shift*, we apply the steering vectors to the corresponding contextual variations $v(x_i)$ and the base scenarios x_i, focusing on negative values for the variations (to attenuate sensitivity) and positive values for the base scenarios (to elicit it). Given that we sweep over 11 possible values for the steering coefficient α, we first test the effectiveness of vectors obtained via different prompt formats and different intervention methods with a temperature of 0 and number of samples $M = 1$. We then evaluate the best setting using all question formats, with the temperature set to 1 and $M = 10$, as done in the LLM survey (Sec. 5.1). We again report the CPS values with non-parametric bootstrap intervals (10,000 resamples) for the full evaluation ($M = 10$).

Additionally, we quantify the steering effect separately for each contextual variation v by fitting a linear mixed-effects model of the form $\text{CPS}_{ik}^{(v)} = \beta_0^{(v)} + \beta_1^{(v)}\alpha_k + b_i^{(v)} + \epsilon_{ik}$. Here, $\beta_0^{(v)}$ denotes the population-level intercept for variation v (representing the expected $\text{CPS}^{(v)}$ at $\alpha = 0$), and $\beta_1^{(v)}$ captures the average change in $\text{CPS}^{(v)}$ per unit increase in steering strength. The random intercepts $b_i^{(v)} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_{b,v}^2)$ and residual errors $\epsilon_{ik} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_{\epsilon,v}^2)$ account for baseline differences across scenarios and observation-level noise, respectively. This specification accounts for the repeated-measures structure of the data, as each scenario is observed across all 11 values of α. We assess the statistical robustness of the steering slope $\beta_1^{(v)}$ via scenario-level bootstrap confidence intervals.

Statistically robust steering along all variations. Summarizing the results of the linear mixed-effects model and the parametric bootstrap analysis, we find that for all three moral variations, the steering slope β_1 is positive and statistically robust, with all 95% parametric bootstrap confidence in-

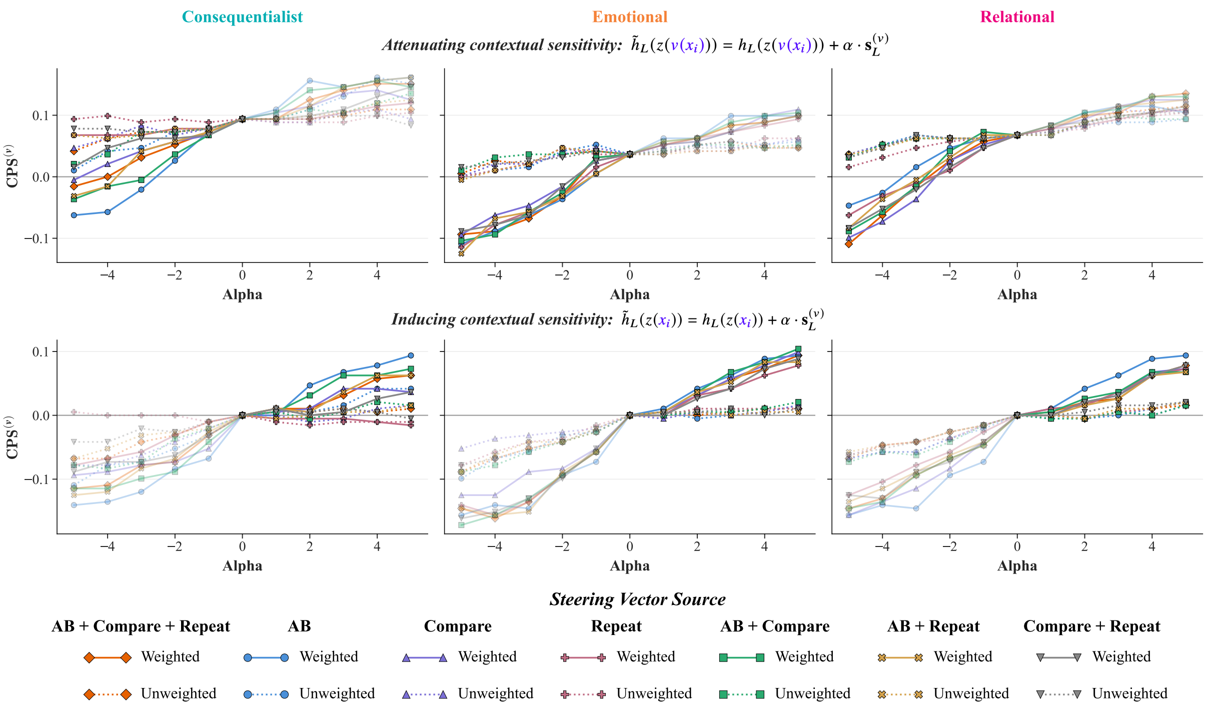

Figure 12: Steering effects across different steering coefficients α, applied *to all tokens*, for contextual variations of scenarios (top row) and base versions of scenarios (bottom row). In the top row, steering is used to attenuate the contextual variation, hence the focus on negative α values. In the bottom row, steering is used to induce contextual sensitivity, with primary interest in positive α values.

Variation (Layer)	**Intra-Format Consistency**			**Cross-Format Similarity**		
	A/B	*Compare*	*Repeat*	*A/B + Compare*	*A/B + Repeat*	*Compare + Repeat*
Consequentialist (L13)	0.2036	0.1553	0.1610	0.3688	0.4376	0.2008
Emotional (L14)	0.2026	0.1603	0.1640	0.3668	0.4740	0.2430
Relational (L15)	0.1331	0.1272	0.1116	0.4220	0.5041	0.3108

Table 19: Cosine similarity analysis of difference vectors $u_l^{(v)}(x_i)$ across vectors derived from different contextual variations. Intra-format consistency measures scenario-invariance within a format, while cross-format values show the semantic alignment between different question formats.

tervals strictly excluding zero. Specifically, in the setting where we apply the vectors to the contextual variations, we observe consistent control of contextual sensitivity across the consequentialist ($\beta_1 = 0.022$), emotional ($\beta_1 = 0.026$), and relational ($\beta_1 = 0.017$) variations. Similarly, when adding the vectors to the base versions, we observe robust preference shifts for the consequentialist ($\beta_1 = 0.025$), emotional ($\beta_1 = 0.028$), and relational ($\beta_1 = 0.020$) variations. We provide the detailed statistical results in Tab. 20 and Tab. 21.

Vector	**Intercept** ($\beta_0^{(v)}$)	**Slope** ($\beta_1^{(v)}$)	**95% CI for** $\beta_1^{(v)}$
Conseq.	0.089	0.022	[0.018, 0.026]
Emo.	0.024	0.026	[0.022, 0.030]
Rel.	0.058	0.017	[0.014, 0.019]

Table 20: Attenuating contextual variations: $\tilde{h}_l(z(v(x_i))) = h_l(z(v(x_i))) + \alpha \cdot \mathbf{s}_l^{(v)}$.

Vector	**Intercept** ($\beta_0^{(v)}$)	**Slope** ($\beta_1^{(v)}$)	**95% CI for** $\beta_1^{(v)}$
Conseq.	−0.006	0.025	[0.021, 0.030]
Emo.	−0.011	0.028	[0.024, 0.032]
Rel.	−0.005	0.020	[0.016, 0.023]

Table 21: Simulating contextual variations: $\tilde{h}_l(z(x_i)) = h_l(z(x_i)) + \alpha \cdot \mathbf{s}_l^{(v)}$.

Attenuating contextual sensitivity. Fig. 14 shows the distribution of CPS values across different values of the steering coefficient α when steering is applied to the *contextual variations* of

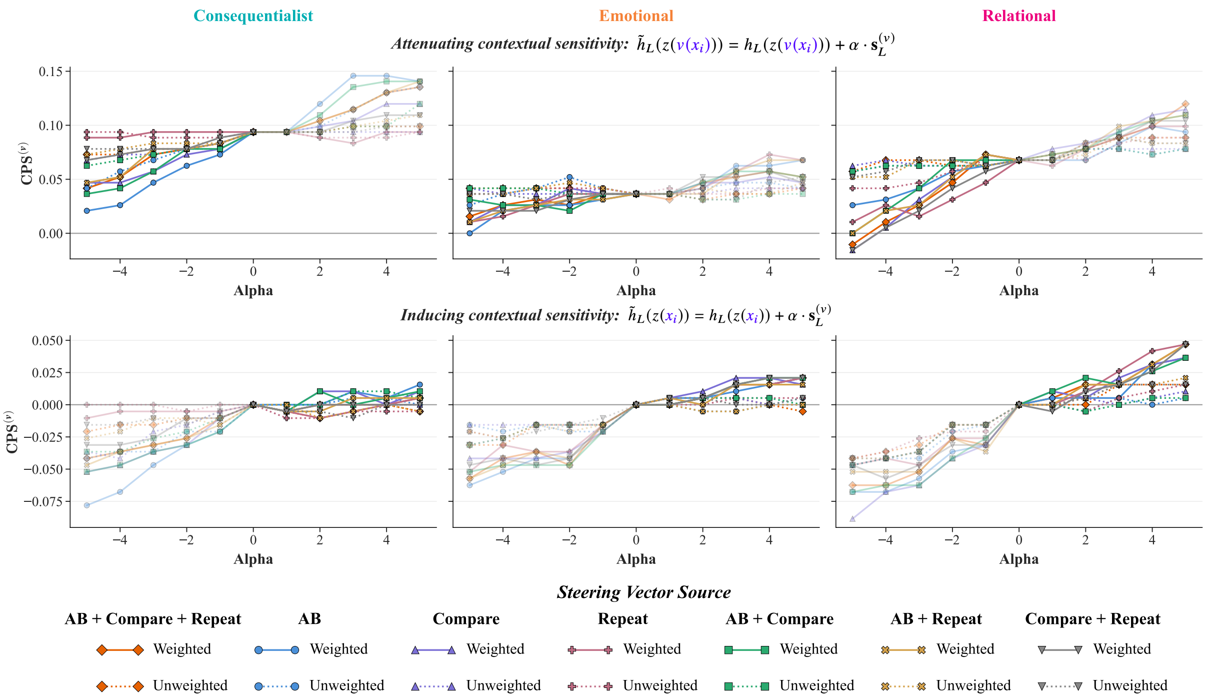

Figure 13: Steering effects across different steering coefficients α, applied *only to the last token of the prompt*, for contextual variations of scenarios (top row) and base versions of scenarios (bottom row). In the top row, steering is used to attenuate the contextual variation, hence the focus on negative α values. In the bottom row, steering is used to induce contextual sensitivity, with primary interest in positive α values.

the scenarios. For negative values of α, we observe that the majority of the distribution mass lies around and below 0, indicating that the steering successfully attenuates the model's contextual sensitivity.

Inducing contextual sensitivity. Fig. 15 shows the distribution of CPS values across different values of the steering coefficient α when steering is applied to the *base versions* of the scenarios. For positive values of α, we observe that the majority of the distribution mass lies around and above 0, indicating that the steering successfully induces the contextual sensitivity and elicits a similar contextual preference shift as we observe when we present the model with the contextual variation in natural language.

F.4 Steering effects on off-target tasks

As we can see in Fig. 16, while we observe slightly degraded benchmark performance for stronger steering, there is substantial variability by task and variation. On *MMLU*, we observe a classic performance trade-off where accuracy declines as the magnitude of $|\alpha|$ increases, yet the total drop is restricted to a modest range of 1–3 percentage points. The consequentialist vector demonstrates the highest stability in this domain. *HellaSwag* exhibits a similar degradation at extreme values, yet notably, the consequentialist and emotional vectors achieve their peak performance at non-zero α values, though these gains remain marginal (within 1 p.p.) and suggest that light steering does not necessarily compromise linguistic coherence. For the *ETHICS* benchmark, the relational vector proves remarkably robust, maintaining high accuracy across the α spectrum, indicating that steering across the relational direction in the subspace does not affect the general moral judgment performance of the model. In contrast, the consequentialist and emotional vectors show a more pronounced trade-off, particularly at higher steering strengths where specialized moral steering begins to diverge from the benchmark's broader normative frameworks.

Tab. 22 shows the results of the different sub-

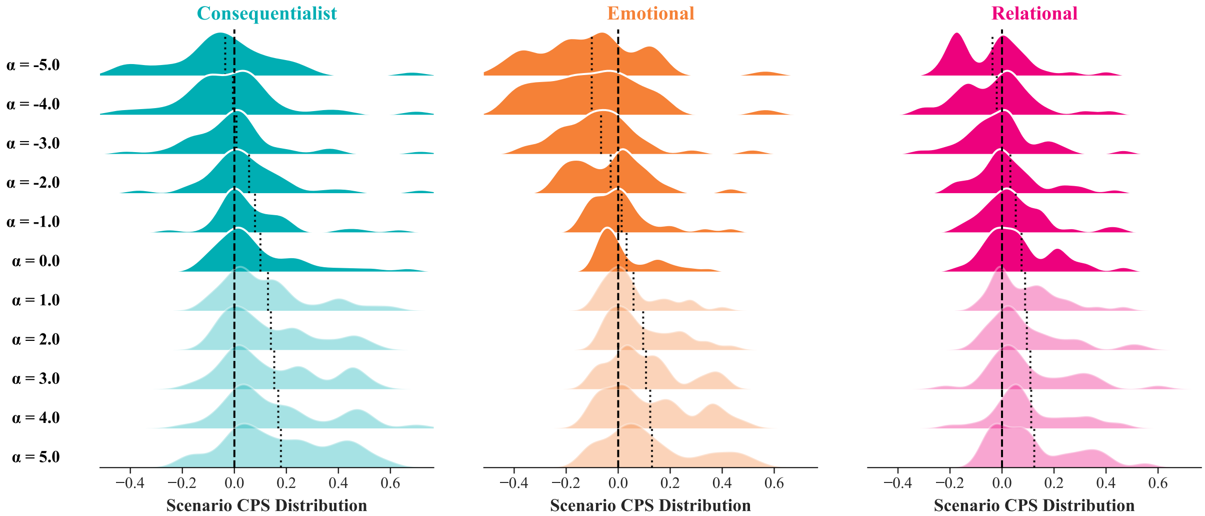

Figure 14: Distribution of the *Contextual Preference Shift* scores across steering coefficients α for each variation vector when applied *to the contextual variation* of the scenarios. Positive (negative) α values shift the distribution rightward (leftward), indicating that vector steering systematically modulates contextual action preferences.

tasks on the MMLU-dataset (Hendrycks et al., 2021b). Across all sub-tasks, we observe that values of α between 0 and 2 result in the highest accuracies.

Tab. 23 reports performance on the sub-tasks of the ETHICS dataset (Hendrycks et al., 2021a). For the "Deontology" and "Justice" sub-tasks, accuracies remain unchanged across all tested values of the steering coefficient α. Notably, for the "Commonsense" sub-task, performance consistently peaks at large positive values of α across all three contextual variations. This indicates that steering actually improves commonsense moral judgments. For the "Virtue" sub-task, we observe the opposite trend: the highest accuracies are achieved for negative values of α.

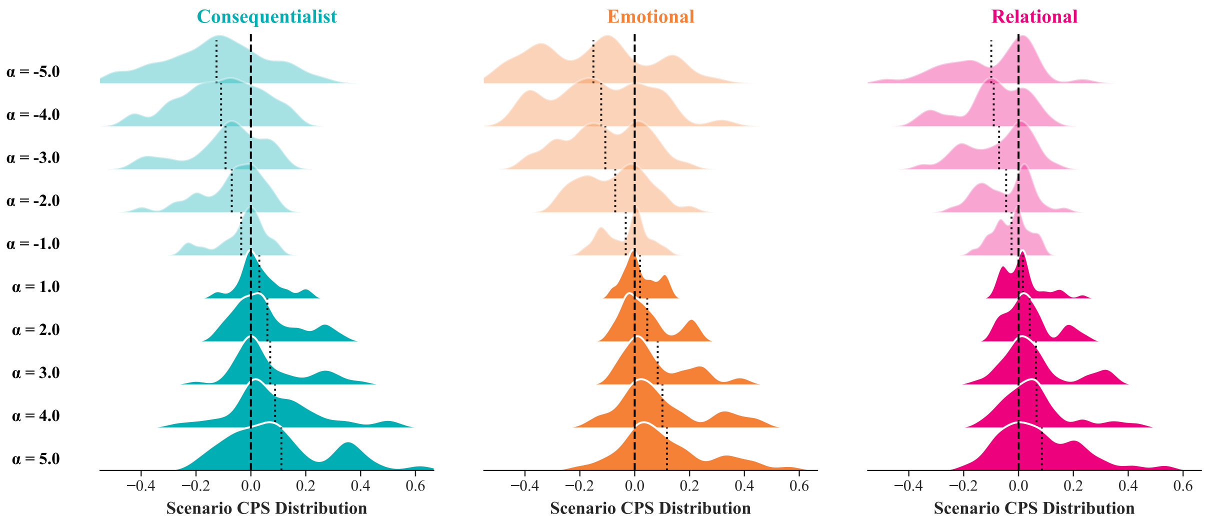

Figure 15: Distribution of the *Contextual Preference Shift* scores across steering coefficients α for each variation vector when applied *to the base versions* of the scenarios. Positive (negative) α values shift the distribution rightward (leftward), indicating that vector steering systematically modulates contextual action preferences. In this setting, we skip the visualization for $\alpha = 0$ since applying no steering to the base version leaves preferences unchanged, rendering the CPS trivially zero by definition.

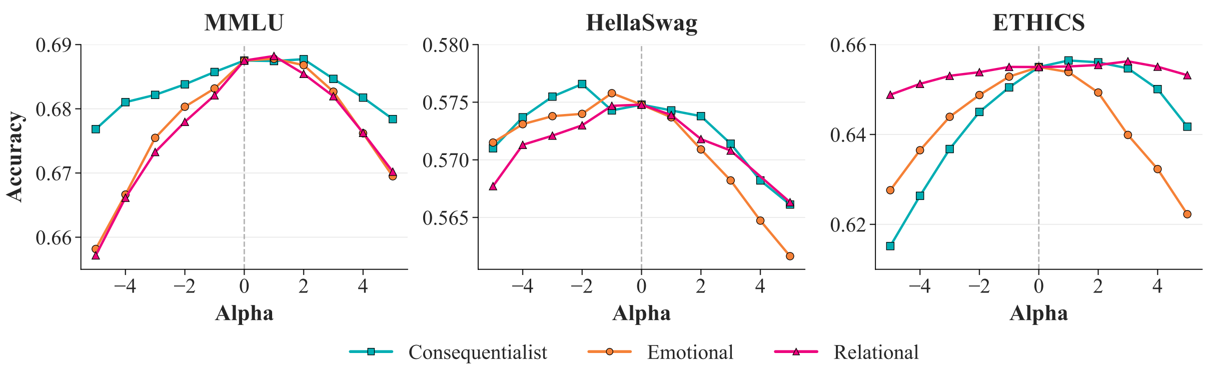

Figure 16: Impact of steering intensities (α) on general knowledge (*MMLU*), linguistic reasoning (*HellaSwag*), and normative moral reasoning (*ETHICS*). While a marginal accuracy drop is observed at higher magnitudes of $|\alpha|$, the model maintains high task performance within the range of steering coefficients that effectively modulate contextual sensitivity.

Vector	α	STEM	Social Sci.	Humanities	Other	Macro Avg.
Consequentialist	-5.0	0.575	0.773	0.643	0.736	**0.677**
	-4.0	0.581	0.775	0.647	0.741	**0.681**
	-3.0	0.582	0.775	0.648	0.743	**0.682**
	-2.0	0.586	0.776	0.650	0.744	**0.684**
	-1.0	0.591	0.779	0.647	0.747	**0.686**
	0.0	0.593	<u>0.782</u>	0.650	0.747	**0.688**
	1.0	<u>0.596</u>	0.779	<u>0.651</u>	0.745	**0.687**
	2.0	<u>0.596</u>	0.780	0.649	<u>0.749</u>	<u>**0.688**</u>
	3.0	0.593	0.775	0.645	0.748	**0.685**
	4.0	0.589	0.774	0.642	0.745	**0.682**
	5.0	0.584	0.772	0.636	0.745	**0.678**
Emotional	-5.0	0.563	0.762	0.610	0.725	**0.658**
	-4.0	0.572	0.764	0.623	0.732	**0.667**
	-3.0	0.582	0.773	0.634	0.737	**0.675**
	-2.0	0.582	0.776	0.643	0.742	**0.680**
	-1.0	0.589	0.776	0.646	0.743	**0.683**
	0.0	0.593	<u>0.782</u>	0.650	<u>0.747</u>	**0.688**
	1.0	0.596	0.781	<u>0.650</u>	0.745	<u>**0.688**</u>
	2.0	<u>0.598</u>	0.781	0.646	0.744	**0.687**
	3.0	0.596	0.780	0.638	0.742	**0.683**
	4.0	0.593	0.775	0.628	0.736	**0.676**
	5.0	0.590	0.772	0.615	0.732	**0.669**
Relational	-5.0	0.559	0.764	0.609	0.724	**0.657**
	-4.0	0.568	0.773	0.619	0.732	**0.666**
	-3.0	0.579	0.776	0.626	0.739	**0.673**
	-2.0	0.587	0.775	0.635	0.740	**0.678**
	-1.0	0.587	0.778	0.643	0.743	**0.682**
	0.0	0.593	<u>0.782</u>	0.650	<u>0.747</u>	**0.688**
	1.0	<u>0.598</u>	0.781	<u>0.652</u>	0.743	<u>**0.688**</u>
	2.0	<u>0.598</u>	0.780	0.647	0.740	**0.685**
	3.0	0.594	0.775	0.642	0.739	**0.682**
	4.0	0.586	0.774	0.636	0.732	**0.676**
	5.0	0.582	0.767	0.626	0.731	**0.670**

Table 22: Detailed 5-shot benchmark accuracy results for the MMLU dataset (Hendrycks et al., 2021b). Values represent accuracy across eleven steering coefficients (α) for vectors derived from three different contextual variations. For each variation and sub-task, the highest accuracy is <u>underlined</u>.

Vector	α	Commonsense	Deontology	Justice	Utilitarianism	Virtue	Macro Avg.
Consequentialist	-5.0	0.656	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.615	0.808	**0.615**
	-4.0	0.667	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.638	0.829	**0.626**
	-3.0	0.681	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.660	0.845	**0.637**
	-2.0	0.692	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.676	0.859	**0.645**
	-1.0	0.700	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.690	0.865	**0.651**
	0.0	0.708	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.701	<u>0.868</u>	**0.655**
	1.0	0.711	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.707</u>	0.867	**<u>0.657</u>**
	2.0	0.716	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.705	0.861	**0.656**
	3.0	<u>0.718</u>	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.705	0.854	**0.655**
	4.0	0.714	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.700	0.839	**0.650**
	5.0	0.708	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.689	0.814	**0.642**
Emotional	-5.0	0.586	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.689	0.866	**0.628**
	-4.0	0.620	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.691	0.874	**0.637**
	-3.0	0.649	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.698	<u>0.876</u>	**0.644**
	-2.0	0.673	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.701</u>	0.873	**0.649**
	-1.0	0.694	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.701</u>	0.872	**0.653**
	0.0	0.708	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.701</u>	0.868	**<u>0.655</u>**
	1.0	0.715	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.696	0.862	**0.654**
	2.0	0.716	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.684	0.849	**0.649**
	3.0	0.717	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.655	0.830	**0.640**
	4.0	<u>0.722</u>	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.633	0.809	**0.632**
	5.0	0.720	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.612	0.783	**0.622**
Relational	-5.0	0.694	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.683	0.869	**0.649**
	-4.0	0.699	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.686	<u>0.875</u>	**0.651**
	-3.0	0.704	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.688	<u>0.875</u>	**0.653**
	-2.0	0.705	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.693	0.874	**0.654**
	-1.0	0.707	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.701	0.870	**0.655**
	0.0	0.708	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.701	0.868	**0.655**
	1.0	0.711	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.702</u>	0.866	**0.655**
	2.0	0.709	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.702</u>	0.868	**<u>0.656</u>**
	3.0	0.712	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	<u>0.702</u>	0.869	**<u>0.656</u>**
	4.0	<u>0.713</u>	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.693	0.872	**0.655**
	5.0	0.708	<u>0.497</u>	<u>0.501</u>	0.687	0.874	**0.653**

Table 23: Detailed 0-shot benchmark accuracy results for the sub-tasks of the ETHICS dataset (Hendrycks et al., 2021a). Values represent accuracy across eleven steering coefficients (α) for vectors derived from three different contextual variations. For each variation and sub-task, the highest accuracy is <u>underlined</u>.

G Extended Discussion

Contextual sensitivity vs. response instability. While prior work suggests LLMs may be overly sensitive to superficial prompt variations (Oh and Demberg, 2025), we employ the framework of Scherrer et al. (2023) to marginalize over semantically equivalent prompts. This approach ensures the elicitation of robust moral preferences, which is a prerequisite for analyzing the contextual sensitivity. The statistical significance of our results, alongside categorical preference reversals in models with decisive baselines, indicates that, for the majority of models, these shifts are not artifacts of stochastic uncertainty or prompt instability. Instead, they represent a genuine reaction to context, suggesting that the sensitivity of several LLMs is a structured behavior that warrants detailed evaluation of its direction and alignment with human judgment.

Alignment and moral discernment. While LLMs often show directional alignment with human moral intuitions, they diverge significantly in magnitude. Large-scale models frequently exhibit "hyper-sensitivity" to specific linguistic cues while remaining rigid in scenarios where humans shift substantially. We hypothesize that this stems from a shallow alignment with surface values (Ashkinaze et al., 2025), where models respond to changes in linguistic structure rather than internalized moral logic. Crucially, increased scaling does not bridge this gap, suggesting that parameter count alone cannot induce deep value internalization. This confirms a distinction between replicating ethical intuitions (the *what*) and possessing the moral competence to weigh competing factors (the *why*) (Kilov et al., 2025). We thus characterize LLM contextual sensitivity as pattern-based mimicry: a byproduct of high-weight token associations rather than genuine normative discernment.

Normative goal of sensitivity. We identify three distinct paradigms for navigating this tension and discuss their impact on AI safety and deployment.

The first is a *refusal-based paradigm*, where models generally decline to answer prompts that involve moral dilemmas to avoid the risks of bias or prescriptive harm (Miehling et al., 2024). However, we view this option as insufficient. There are numerous ways to bypass explicit refusals through creative prompting, and as LLMs are integrated into collaborative decision-making, the ability to process moral nuance becomes a functional requirement rather than an optional feature.

A second approach is the *rigidly-objective paradigm*, which prioritizes deterministic consistency. In this view, a model's response to moral scenarios should remain anchored to a normative floor regardless of how a scenario is framed. This is desirable for institutional applications where fairness requires identical treatment of identical cases and where contextual shifts that do not alter the underlying moral structure are ignored. However, this approach risks "contextual blindness": it is disadvantageous if a model is so robust that it ignores morally significant variations, such as the difference between a routine action and an urgent necessity. Prior work has proposed to teach the models to ask relevant clarification questions in morally ambiguous scenarios to resolve this tension (Pyatkin et al., 2023). Yet, this does not address the broader challenge of value pluralism, i.e., *which* values models should reflect. To circumvent this, models could be equipped to adjust to a user's specific policy or value system (Rao et al., 2023). However, while feasible for institutional users with fixed protocols, we argue that it remains unrealistic to expect individual users to consistently articulate a comprehensive moral framework to guide every interaction.

The third option is a *human-centric sensitivity paradigm*, in which models are designed to reproduce human-like contextual sensitivity. Under this view, if a user provides specific contextual details, the model is expected to weigh them accordingly to maximize human-likeness and utility. However, our findings suggest that the current state of sensitivity in LLMs is shallow and driven by linguistic salience and pattern-based mimicry rather than a deep internalization of moral values. This superficial alignment leaves models vulnerable to adversarial manipulation and the over-amplification of human biases inherent in training data (Cheung et al., 2025; Santurkar et al., 2023). While recent work has attempted to better align LLMs with human moral values (Tennant et al., 2024), these efforts still face the challenge of value pluralism: deciding which of the many competing human moral frameworks a model should sensitively adapt to.

H Future Work

Building on the findings of our work, several directions for future research emerge, all aimed at developing a more robust and mechanistically grounded understanding of contextual moral sensitivity in LLMs.

Cross-cultural and cross-lingual evaluation. A critical next step is to extend the evaluation framework to multilingual and non-WEIRD contexts (Henrich et al., 2010). Future research should evaluate whether the contextual sensitivity patterns observed in English-language scenarios are replicated in other languages, or if cultural-linguistic framing substantially alters a model's moral landscape. Beyond behavioral evaluation, the cross-lingual transferability of steering vectors warrants investigation. It remains an open question whether a steering vector extracted from an English corpus can effectively modulate activations when the model is prompted in a different language. Comparing this geometry of morality across language-specific models could reveal whether certain ethical sensitivities are universal artifacts of scale-based pre-training or culturally specific to the dominant language of the training corpus.

Automated discovery of latent normative dimensions. While this work focuses on three predefined moral dimensions, future work could employ unsupervised or contrastive methods to discover the full manifold of moral salience within LLMs. Recent advancements in *Sparse Autoencoders* (SAEs) have demonstrated that it is possible to decompose LLM activations into millions of interpretable features without manual labeling (Bricken et al., 2023; Templeton, 2024). By applying similar dictionary learning techniques to the activation space across diverse, unstructured corpora, one might be able to identify latent moral tendencies that a model has developed during training, which might be different from traditional human ethical categories (Schramowski et al., 2022).

Circuit-level localization of contextual sensitivity. Moving from representation engineering to mechanistic interpretability, future studies should aim to localize the specific transformer circuits responsible for processing contextual variations. Techniques such as path patching (Wang et al., 2022a) or activation scrubbing (Chan et al., 2022) could be used to identify whether the sensitivity we observe is concentrated in specific attention heads or if it is a property of the activation stream's global geometry.

Probing situational awareness and alignment faking. Recent research suggests that LLMs can exhibit "situational awareness" (Berglund et al., 2023), allowing them to identify when they are being evaluated and strategically alter their responses to appear more aligned with human preferences. This phenomenon can lead to "alignment faking" (Greenblatt et al., 2024), which refers to the models adopting a specific test-taking persona that prioritizes safety-consistent outputs over their actual internal representations. Future work should investigate whether the contextual sensitivity and steering vectors identified in this work remain stable across different personas or environment framings. For instance, comparing activations extracted from a direct moral survey against those from a naturalistic setting (e.g., creative writing or private dialogue) could reveal the difference between a model's true normative manifold and its evaluative facade. Understanding this gap is crucial to ensure that steering interventions remain effective in real-world deployments rather than merely within the confines of the evaluation setting.

I Potential Risks

While this work is intended to expose and characterize a gap in current alignment practices, several risks warrant acknowledgment. Most directly, the activation steering methodology presented in Sec. 6 could be repurposed by adversarial actors with white-box model access to deliberately suppress moral rule-adherence at inference time. Beyond misuse of the steering technique itself, publicly releasing scenarios designed to elicit rule-violating responses under consequentialist, emotional, and relational framing could enable their use as adversarial prompt templates against deployed systems. Finally, our comparison with human survey data should not be taken to imply that human judgment is a normatively ideal calibration target; given the documented parochialism effects in the relational condition and the WEIRD skew of our participant sample (App. D.4.2), steering models towards human-like sensitivity risks encoding rather than correcting for human biases.